The Political Geography of Identity:
Local Determinants of Pan-Ethnicity among Asian Americans

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Abstract
How does one's community shape their racialized and political identity? Research studying group-based resources and political behavior focuses primarily on the overall size of a group. This study refines our understanding of how community shapes Asian pan-ethnic identity by examining a second dimension of population beyond group size: Asian national origin diversity. Using both existing and new survey data, I find that Asians living in more heterogeneous areas view Asian identity as less important and also report lower levels of Asian linked fate. I then examine variation in the role of physical and social resources across localities based on group size and diversity. Respondents in localities with larger populations and lower levels of diversity are more likely to both report higher levels of pan-Asian salience and availability of cultural resources. My analysis highlights the role of within-group heterogeneity, as well as importance of community resources and cultural institutions in cultivating the connection between identity and politics.

Keywords: Local context, group identity, linked fate, Asian American politics

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Introduction

How do population characteristics affect the link between group identity and group politics? Research on identity and politics generally agrees that shared identity is important. For example, individuals are more likely to vote for a political candidate with whom they share a group identity (Bobo and Gilliam 1990). Key to this relationship are theories of racial context, which consider political outcomes as a function of the relative size of a group in an area. Prior work has found that attachment to group identity and political engagement among members increase as group size increases (Miller et al. 1981) and argues that group size is the driving force behind identity-related preferences. Thus, voting for co-racial candidates is not a function of shared identity per se but of the supply of co-racial candidates due to a larger population (Fraga 2016). However, research on context overlooks an additional factor: group diversity.

What happens when the group itself is relatively heterogeneous and comprised of different subgroups? As the size of the overall group changes, within-group population dynamics may complicate expectations about group identification and, consequently, political behavior around group interests. In the case of Asian Americans, there is documented variation in pan-ethnic identification relative to an individual's national origin or ethnic identification (Wong et al. 2011; Lien et al. 2001). Understanding the consequences of within-group dynamics is crucial to understanding the role of group size in facilitating the connection between individual identity and political outcomes that have been extensively studied in prior research. This research, however, often takes for granted the role of group homogeneity. If national origin group boundaries are distinct, the salience of pan-ethnic identity may lessen due to divergent interests and attitudes of the different subgroups. Findings from prior work accounting only for group size may be masking important dynamics between institutional features and political outcomes.

This paper examines group identification as a function of the group's population context. I argue that accounts relying on a population-based explanation for group politics need to account for within-group heterogeneity in addition to size. In doing so, I unite two separate strands of literature, theories of context and theories of pan-ethnic identification to provide a theoretical basis for understanding how and when pan-ethnic identities become meaningful. I focus on the Asian community in the United States and build on research that emphasizes the distinctions within the pan-ethnic label between national origin groups. Though the role of group diversity is an important consideration for any group that has sufficient subgroup differences, Asian Americans provide a robust benchmark for this exploration.[1] Cultural differences between Asian national origin groups are likely more salient given strong ties to countries of origin (Lee 2015). Unlike other groups, Asians do not have a common non-English language, increasing the costs of navigating group divisions. Thus, Asian Americans arguably present a least-likely case for the emergence of pan-ethnic identity such that examining the effect of group heterogeneity is most notable in this setting.

To examine the relationship between population dynamics and Asian pan-ethnic identification, I analyze a typology of localities using two dimensions of population: group size and group diversity. Using Census population data, I create a measure of Asian group size based on the proportion of Asians in a locality relative to the total population. I also create a measure of Asian national origin diversity that captures the degree of heterogeneity within the Asian community in a locality. This 2x2 typology permits the following characterization of localities: places that are 1) Large Population and High Diversity, 2) Large Population and Low Diversity, 3) Small Population and High Diversity, and 4) Small Population and Low Diversity. Using original survey data, I then examine the potential institutions and social mechanisms that connect population dimensions to pan-Asian identification and compare their presence across the four types of localities. A key assumption in this theorization is that institutional structures and social relations reflect differences in group size and diversity in those places.

Using data from the 2016 Collaborative Multiracial Post-Election Survey (CMPS), I find that accounting for group diversity, beyond group size, reveals significant differences in pan-Asian identification among Asian respondents in different localities. While individuals in localities with a larger Asian population more strongly identify as Asian (as prior work would predict), there are diverging results when we account for the diversity of the Asian community. Places with larger Asian populations and higher levels of diversity report *lower* levels of identification and linked fate with other Asians. On the other hand, in areas with a lower level of national origin diversity (i.e., where one national origin group comprises a large proportion of the Asian community), Asian individuals express *higher* levels of group attachment. Second, results from a novel survey show that respondents in localities with large Asian populations and lower levels of diversity are more likely to report higher levels of community resources. However, we do not see similar discernible differences between localities for intergroup relations, highlighting the role of cultural resources and organizations in strengthening pan-Asian identity. In the following, I provide an overview of prior research on racial context and group size, describe and present analysis from the CMPS and a novel survey, and conclude with recommendations for future work studying racial context and identity.

Background

Group Identity and Context

Group identity is an important feature of politics. On the elite side, identity serves as a heuristic, filling in informational gaps about politicians' ideology and policy preferences (Jones 2013; Karl and Ryan 2016). For the mass public, shared identity can serve as a means of organize collective interests, making coordination around group-related interests more feasible (Habyarimana et al. 2007). The ability of shared identity to organize political interests is particularly salient in the context of Asian American politics, given barriers to developing a pan-ethnic identity arising from differences in culture and language between national origin subgroups. Asian pan-ethnicity only emerged in the late 1960's among Asian student activists, many of whom were second generation immigrants, when English became available as a means of communication and coordination (Espiritu 1992).

The importance of Asian group identity is well-documented. Asian Americans are more likely to register and turn out to vote for an Asian candidate than for a non-Asian candidate (Uhlaner and Le 2017; Sadhwani 2021; Leung 2021) and are also more likely to view Asian candidates more favorably than non-Asian candidates (Schildkraut 2013). Experimental work attributes these relationships to the politicization of Asian identity (Junn and Masuoka 2008). Behaviorally, stronger group identification may increase non-voting political engagement, such as campaign contributions (Lien 1994; Wong et al. 2005). This body of work generally agrees that Asian group identity has political consequences, especially among stronger identifiers. However, these findings may conflate the factors that explain both pan-Asian identity salience and political outcomes by overlooking geographic factors.

A compelling line of research emphasizes the role of *context* in shaping politically salient identities and behaviors, primarily due to socialization processes facilitated by local conditions (Huckfeldt, Plutzer, and Sprague 1993). Though scholars variously refer to "racial", "social", or "population" context, they are common in their characterization of salient place-based features. Context encompasses the structures and experiences that reinforce and inform an individual's sense of identity and place in politics. In this way, group identification can be thought of as an expression of the very structures and experiences encountered on a daily basis in one's locality.

Theories of context can thus be used to argue that identity itself is not necessarily the salient feature driving preferences and behaviors but local context. This is not to say that identity is unimportant, but rather that the presence of factors that encourage identification and group-oriented attitudes are likely confounded with population characteristics. For example, in places with a larger Asian population, we may expect there to be more community organizations that actively promote national origin or pan-Asian events, which may be why research finds stronger pan-Asian identification and political mobilization in those areas. Notably, extant work on context overlooks the role of subgroup characteristics and considering how divisions *within* a group may contribute to the documented effects of context on outcomes. This study characterizes two dimensions – group size and group diversity - within local context that structure the development and maintenance of Asian group identity.

Context and Group Size

Research studying the role of context usually measures it as the relative proportion of a racial group in a geographic area and has established a link between identity and population density of a group in a locality. Bledsoe et al. (1995) find that Black Americans living in predominantly Black neighborhoods report greater racial solidarity. Lau (1989) outlines several similar explanations for why "social density" of a community matters for the maintenance and development of group identity, all of which suggest that the larger one's group is, the more likely one is to identify with the group. Notably, Lau posits an upper bound to the effect of group size – when social density is high, we should expect less identification with the group because the need for a group identity decreases. Along these lines, Rim (2009) finds that the role of linked fate in mediating political behavior is attenuated for Asians who live in Honolulu, where a majority of the population is Asian.

Anoll, Davenport, and Lienesch (2025) provide guidance for understanding the means by which context matters by separating it into three types: geographic context (relative proportion within a geography), social context (the ties one has with ingroup members), and psychological context (self-reported closeness). By characterizing context in these varieties, researchers can be more specific about which features of context actually matter, whether it be the exposure to ingroup members, the social aspects of community, or psychological effects. Importantly, this conception of context parallels another strand that understands context as a function of local resources, broadly defined. Ethier and Deaux (1994) show that group identity is maintained by ethnic-oriented resources that affect an individual's ability to think about themselves in terms of a specific group identity. However, they also find selection effects in the consumption of the resource based on whether one is strong identifier (and thus more likely to access resources) or a weak identifier (and more likely to be threatened by the prevalence of resources). Wilcox-Archuleta (2018) demonstrates the importance of "ethnic stimuli" in a locality, highlighting the presence of and interactions with ethnic-named businesses and other co-ethnics as factors that increase the importance of group identity. This line of research emphasizes the importance of local structures in facilitating the types of interactions between individuals that either strengthen or weaken their attachment to a racialized identity (Lawler et al. 1993, Jimenez 2010). Sanchez and Masuoka (2010) further this argument by showing a positive relationship between social context and group identity importance. Similar to "ethnic stimuli" is a characterization of social capital in Zhou (2009), which reflects the social structures and local institutions in neighborhoods that provide targeted resources to immigrant communities. Moreover, Okamoto

(2006) emphasizes the importance of organizations and structural conditions can promote or deter pan-ethnic coordination.

In addition to facilitating social interactions, these local structures may reflect targeted political efforts wherein community organizations are prime channels through which campaigns or targeted policy implementations can mobilize co-racial individuals (Cho, Gimpel, and Dyck 2006; Nuamah and Ogorzalek 2021). The consequence of these efforts have been well-documented: as the Asian population in an area increases, turnout among Asian voters also increases, often regardless of whether the candidate is Asian (Fraga 2018; Jang 2009; Sadhwani 2022). Moreover, not only do turnout and participation increase, but so does symbolic representation of group interests from White politicians (Vishwanath 2024) and subsequent entry of Asian candidates (Fraga, Gonzalez, and Shah 2020).

Beyond structural and social resources, there is ample evidence that local context often reflect salient social and psychological processes as a function of group size. The contact hypothesis, which argues that the growing presence of an outgroup often increases positive affect towards that group (e.g., Oliver and Wong 2003), though mixed (e.g., Enos 2014, Key 1949, Bobo and Hutchings 1996), highlights the importance of interactions between racial groups as one grows in size. Experiences with discrimination, political mobilization, local community structures, and involvement in local networks all likely matter. Local context can be framed as a summary construct of exposure to others, potentially ingroup or outgroup, and of the politicized experiences that come about as a function of population dynamics. This framing naturally raises the question of variation in exposure: if we believe that the presence and the degree of presence of other groups is a politicizing process, then we must consider which groups one is being exposed to. Studies of context typically characterize ingroups based on racial background and overlook ingroups that may exist *within* a pan-ethnic group.

Accounting for Group Diversity

Undergirding the research on group size and context is the assumption that group identity is a coherent label and that population size is a sufficient metric for capturing group presence in politically-relevant contexts (e.g., electoral districts). The usefulness of group size as a measure is attributable to the relations between one's ingroup and an outgroup. As a marginalized ingroup grows in size, incentives to coalesce around a mobilizable identity increase, usually in response to increasing pressures from a dominant outgroup seeking to maintain social order (Quillian 1995; Hainmueller and Hopkins 2014). Pan-ethnicity in this context emerges instrumentally in response to potential threats or incentives to group attachment. Moreover, the role of group size in increasing the saliency of physical or social resources in contributing to group identity makes sense when groups are relatively homogenous and face lower costs of coalition-building (Jang 2009; Lien 2004). However, what happens when the group itself is subjected to potential divisions? Asian pan-ethnicity complicates these assumptions, given the degree of heterogeneity in national origin (Okamura 2008) - whereas group size affects outgroup tensions, group diversity affects ingroup tensions.

Socially, diversity of a pan-ethnic community has implications for how connected subgroups feel towards each other and to communal identity. Whether the image of "Asian America" applies to an individual depends on where they stand within their community. Gay (2004) finds evidence showing that not only does group size matter, but so does the socio-economic status of the people in the group. Relatedly, Junn (2007) describes the process by which the image of Asian America shifted from "coolie to model minority" due in part to the influx of high-status workers after the Exclusion Act was repealed in 1965. Heterogeneity also potentially affects the nature of intergroup relations between individuals of different national origin backgrounds. As Okamoto and Mora (2014) articulate, pan-ethnicity is not static but rather a byproduct of “an inherent tension derived from maintaining subgroup distinctions while developing a sense of metagroup unity.” Someone who lives in a predominantly Chinese community may have a different conception of “Asian”, which may affect their attachment to the Asian identity, especially if they are not Chinese. While this may be a product of residential homophily (Kim and White 2010), the consequence of geographic concentration and distribution of different Asian national origin groups in a locality can be observed in daily interactions with community members and neighbors (Sanders 2002). Findings from Cho, Gimpel, and Dyck (2006) – that local environments facilitate information flow and which is weaker in neighborhoods with greater concentrations of foreign-born residents – suggest that internal differences between Asian national origin groups have meaningful consequences. Individuals' experiences within a community affect identity salience, especially depending on whether one is part of a dominant subgroup in their community and the institutions and resources their community has to facilitate information flow. The salience of pan-Asian identity and one's attachment to it is a response to social incentives structured by local context.

Institutionally, whereas group size may affect *whether* a cultural organization is founded, group diversity may affect the *type* of organization that develops, whether it be one with a pan-ethnic focus for broad appeal or a focus specific to a national origin group. For example, Kim (2020a) shows that pan-Asian coalitions were more likely to form in localities where Asian national origin groups were larger and shared similar political interests, compared to places where subgroups were smaller. In turn, these resulting coalitions and organizations provide resources to support the interests of their local community (see Kim 2020b; Okamoto and Gast 2013). These resources vary in the degree to which they support pan-ethnic identity, depending on how the coalition was formed. Additionally, other forms of structural resources beyond community organizations can speak to the daily lives of residents in a community, spanning from the presence of ethnic restaurants and grocery stores to the visibility of non-English language writing on storefronts.

Expectations for Pan-Ethnic Identity Importance as a Function of Size and Diversity

Key to this paper, diversity does not operate on its own. The theoretical expectations of how group size and group diversity affect pan-ethnic identity must be considered together. Prior work argues that higher levels of intra-Asian diversity and that national origin groups having sufficient numbers to organize on their own can subvert the realization of broader group interests at the pan-ethnic level (Chai 2005; Chandra 2007; Espiritu 1992). The risk of being miscategorized for a different national origin or racialized as just "Asian" can potentially create resentment towards other Asians, particularly when numbers are smaller (Flores and Huo 2013; Steele 1997). Thus, any theory of local context and group identity necessarily needs to be interactive, accounting for both group size and group diversity.

This body of research can be summarized by Table 1, which organizes locality types as a 2x2 matrix defined by Asian population size and national origin diversity. Research on context has largely focused along the column dimension, comparing places based on the size of the Asian community. Pan-Asian identification can reflect a need for identity-relevant resources, which are more available with increasing population size. Moreover, increasing group size of a minoritized group increases the relevance of a group identity with respect to racial outgroups. In areas with relatively smaller Asian populations, opportunities for the emergence or presence of structures that promote a collective group identity are limited compared to areas with larger populations, where individuals are more likely to encounter other Asian individuals and where pan-Asian and ethnic organizations are more likely to be established.

Table 1. Two Dimensions of Place: Locality Types and Asian Group Identity

	Small Asian Population	Large Asian Population
Low National Origin Diversity	**(i) Unclear** *Lower need for pan-Asian ID, but greater feasibility for one*	**(ii) Asian group identity likely important.** *Greater need for pan-Asian ID, and greater feasibility for one*
High National Origin Diversity	**(iii) Asian group identity is likely less important.** *Lower need for pan-Asian ID, and not as feasible*	**(iv) Unclear** *Greater need for pan-Asian ID, but not as feasible*

National origin diversity shapes whether pan-Asian identity is feasible as a coordinating frame among Asian subgroups. More diverse communities will need to overcome greater costs to coordination compared to more homogenous communities. However, these costs are also a function of the size of the pan-ethnic group. In areas with large and homogenous Asian populations (cell ii), pan-Asian identification is most likely to be meaningful, as the larger group size increases the presence and viability of Asian voters and homogeneity permits easier coordination around a shared identity. In contrast, in places with smaller Asian populations that are more diverse (cell iii), pan-Asian identity may be less meaningful because the smaller group size makes it difficult to develop structures to support a pan-Asian identity across all subgroups.

Cells (i) and (iv) represent contexts in which countervailing forces produce less obvious expectations. In areas with smaller, homogenous Asian populations (cell i), incentives for a group identity are more salient, because of their smaller numbers. However, it may be that the need for a pan-Asian identity is lower because a national origin identity provides sufficient coverage. In cell (iv), with a larger population that is more diverse, pan-ethnic identity may be important as a means of optimizing representation and visibility of small Asian subgroups but also may be difficult to achieve given divergent political demands and institutional structures that reflect specific national origin interests. The result is not necessarily the absence of pan-Asian identity, but one that is more instrumental or conditional on external incentives. Worth noting is that the processes that characterize need and feasibility likely differ across localities. For example, while pan-ethnic identity may arise in large and diverse localities as a response to mobilization efforts, in more homogenous localities with larger Asian populations (cell ii), pan-ethnic identity may be important because "Asian" is synonymous with the dominant Asian subgroup, upon which many of the available structures and mobilization efforts are based.

Focusing on the ways in which local geographic characteristics structure group identity helps us better understand the connection between racialized identities and power. In the case of Asian pan-ethnicity, this connection reflects the consequences of institutional efforts to categorize heterogeneous groups of people under one label. The empirical approach of this paper first uses observational analysis to descriptively compare pan-Asian identification across the four different types of localities. I then present data from an original survey to explore potential mechanisms across these localities. The mechanisms measured are derived from extant theories of context and consider two classes of mechanisms: physical resources and social resources.

Measuring Group Size and Diversity

To measure group size, I use population data from the 2018 American Community Survey, which provides 5-year estimates, and calculate the proportion of Asian residents in a zip code relative to the total population in that zip code. The ACS is advantageous to other administrative datasets in providing population data for different national origin groups at the zip-code level. Zip codes are coded as "Small Population" if the Asian population is less than or equal to 15%

and "Large Population" otherwise. The 15% cutoff is based on similar population categories used in Sadhwani (2022) which are based on population distributions in California. The analysis in Sadhwani (2022) suggests that 15% is about the threshold at which we see mobilization of Asian voters and where evidence of identity salience begins to emerge. A fixed threshold is used here, rather than a relative one (e.g. varying across states), so that the classification of localities as "Small" or "Large" reflects comparable levels of group presence that may support similar institutions and structures relevant to group identity processes. The use of zip code as a geographic level of locality may also be subject to critique, given that definitions of community vary not just across person, but also across locality type (rural vs. urban) and region. Wong et al. (2020) show that personal perceptions of geography often do not comport with objective measures based on administrative definitions. Wong et al. (2012), however, suggest that these misperceptions are of more concern at larger-level of geography (e.g., county). Relevant to this study, Velez and Wong (2017) demonstrate that ZCTA-based measures of community correlate better than personalized measures with perceptions of racial group size.

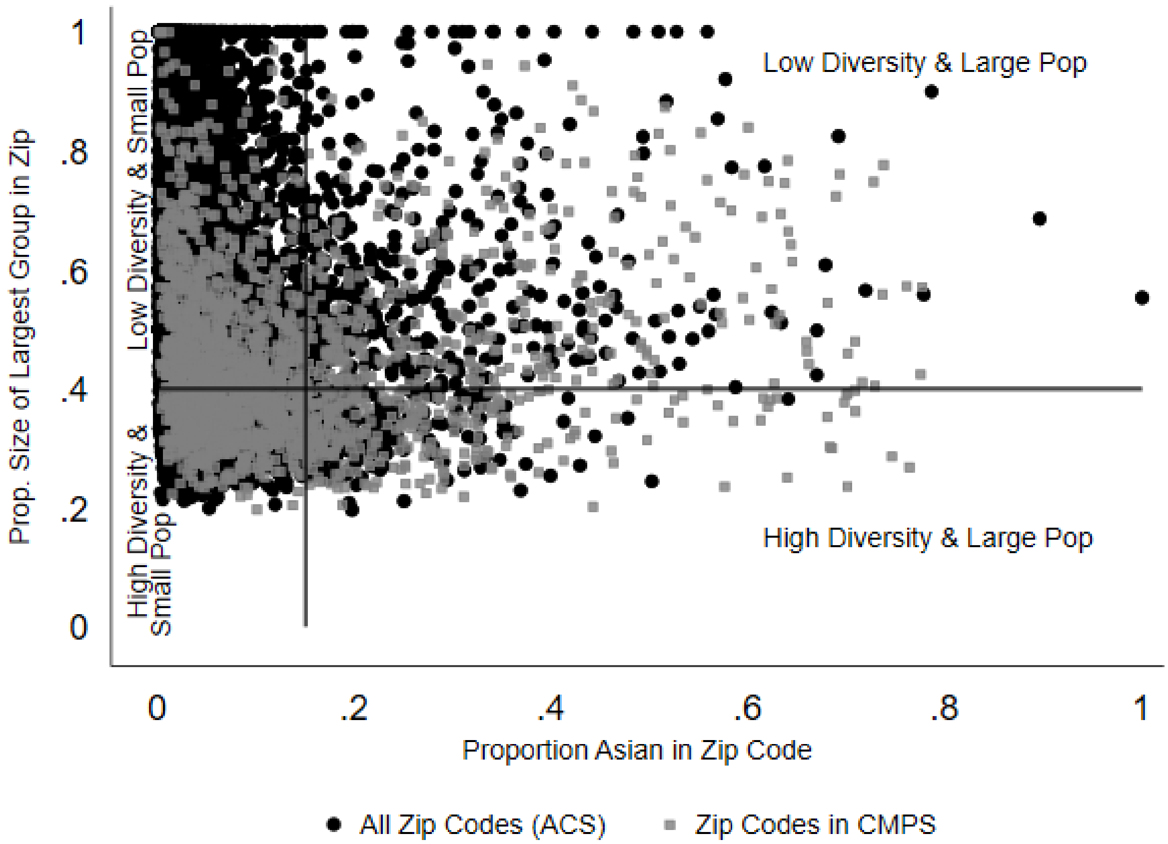
To measure national origin diversity, I compare the size of the largest national origin subgroup in a locality and consider localities to be "High Diversity" when the relative sizes of national origin groups are such that no one group dominates numerically (and "Low Diversity" otherwise). While this measure does not specifically account for the individual sizes of every group present, the *lack* of a dominant group necessarily implies that subgroups have some degree of equal presence, numerically, in the locality. Zip codes where the largest subgroup is less than or equal to 40% of the Asian community are coded as "High Diversity", as no group numerically dominates. Conversely, zip codes in which the largest subgroup is more than 40% of the Asian community are coded as "Low Diversity". The 40% threshold corresponds to the 25th percentile of the proportions of the largest Asian subgroup, as shown in Appendix Table S1. While the 50th percentile value corresponds to a majority (51.8% specifically), I take the lower threshold under the assumption that any influences of group dominance likely emerge before a given subgroup constitutes a majority of the Asian community.

The main analysis focuses on this measure of group dominance for conceptual simplicity (i.e., whether there is a group with a large notable presence), as well as to account for measurement concerns related to data availability. Diversity is measured using data available from the Census, which only records the following national origin groups: Chinese, Indian, Filipino, Japanese, Korean, and Vietnamese. Groups not in this list are recorded as Other. Consequently, calculating a diversity measure like the Herfindahl-Hirschman index (HHI), which mechanically requires data for all relevant groups, may be suboptimal given that national origin groups outside of this list are relegated to the "Other" category. Framing diversity as a question of dominant group presence sidesteps this measurement concern. Nonetheless, I provide robustness checks in considering other measures of diversity, such as the Herfindahl-Hirschman index (HHI) and alternative thresholds (e.g., 50%), as well as supplementary analysis considering the role of an individual's membership in a dominant group.

Figure 1 visualizes the distribution of zip codes across these two dimensions, with Asian population size on the x-axis and the proportion of the largest national origin group on the y-axis. Black circles represent zip codes drawn from the 2018 ACS, representing the entire set of zip codes in the US where there are Asian residents recorded in the Census. Grey squares indicate the zip codes that are also in the CMPS sample. The thresholds used to code areas as High/Low Diversity (40%) and Large/Small Population (15%) are marked by the x and y axes, respectively.

[Figure 1 about here]

Figure 1. National Origin Group Diversity vs. Asian Population Size



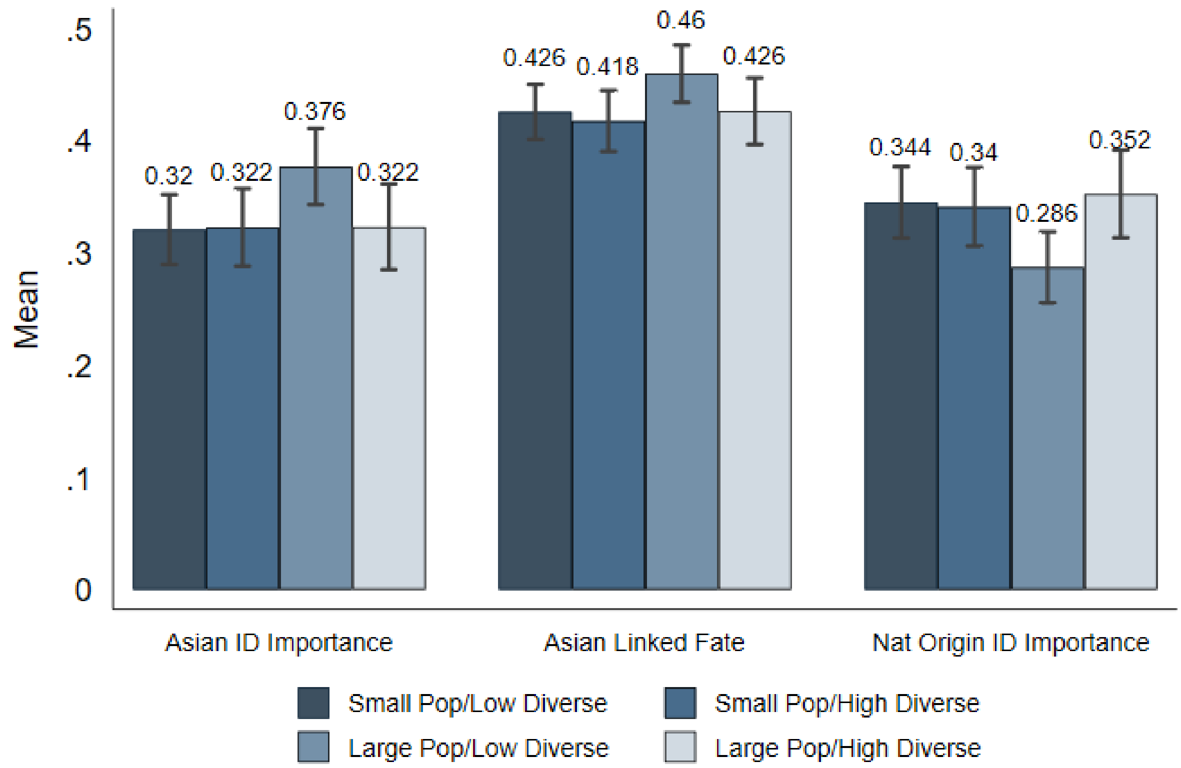
Unsurprisingly, most Asians in the Census live in Small Population zip codes. Adding the second dimension of diversity additionally shows that there is a sizeable degree of variation among localities with small proportions of Asians. Figure 1 suggests that geographic variation may not be limited to or driven only by variation in Asian group size but may need to also factor in within-group heterogeneity. Mechanically, we should expect clustering in the top-left region - as group size decreases, the likelihood that one group will dominate numerically increases. This may be driven by immigration patterns and selection into areas where there are pre-existing national origin ties (Zavodny 1999). It is worth noting is that the distribution of zip codes from the CMPS generally approximates the distribution from the Census, though there is an underrepresentation of zip codes that are Low Diversity and Small Population. I address this concern later in the analysis.

CMPS Analysis: Pan-Asian Identity Importance Across Locality Types

What does Asian identity importance look like across these four locality types? I measure identity importance using data from the 2016 CMPS (Frasure et al. 2016). I restrict the sample to survey participants who identify as Asian (demographic statistics and distributions are provided in Table S2-S4). Asian group identity is captured using three different survey items. The first is a measure of identity importance, in which respondents are asked to rank their Asian identity relative to their national origin and American identities. This item takes a value of 1 if they rank their Asian identity as most important and 0 otherwise. The second is a measure of linked fate: "Do you think what happens generally to Asian people in this country will have something to do with what happens in your life?" Third is a measure of importance for national origin identity, which takes a value of 1 if a respondent ranks it as their most important identity relative to their Asian or American identities. Figure 2 compares the means of these three outcomes across locality types. Individual bars within a cluster, differentiated by color, report the outcome mean for a specific locality type, with 95% confidence intervals, reflecting the proportion of respondents within a particular the of locality. There are several observations worth noting in looking at Asian Identity Importance and Asian Linked Fate, both of which measure attitudes towards the pan-ethnic group.

[Figure 2 about here]

Figure 2. Group Identity Measures across Locality Types



First, consistent with extant research, there are significant gains in identity importance when we go from Small to Large Population among Low Diversity localities. That is, among places that are Low Diversity (more homogeneous), Asian Identity Importance is significantly higher in places that have larger populations (difference = 0.05, std err = 0.02). This is also true for Asian Linked Fate (diff = 0.03, std err = 0.01). Second, identity is less important in areas with greater diversity that also are Large Population. In places with larger populations, there is a significant decrease in identity importance in High Diversity areas compared to Low Diversity areas, going from 0.376 to 0.322 (diff = 0.05, std err = 0.02). Finally, though there are notable differences between Asian identity importance and Asian linked fate, with the latter being significantly higher than the former, the patterns within each measure are nonetheless similar across the two (Figure S1 presents these results with standardized values). Overall, we see suggestive evidence that identity is more salient in localities with larger Asian populations, but that are also more homogenous. For reference, a regression-based version of Figure 2 is provided in Table S6, along with a covariate-adjusted specification with similar patterns in the adjusted-means.

We see a different story with ethnic or national origin identity importance. Similarly, in Large Population areas, moving from a High to Low Diversity locality (increasing homogeneity) decreases national origin identity importance (diff = 0.06, std err = 0.02), as opposed to increasing Asian identity importance. Because the two identity importance measures are mutually exclusive - respondents are asked to rank order their pan-ethnic and national origin identities – we can interpret the difference as a change in the relative importance ordering of pan-Asian identity over national origin identity in Large Population/Low Diversity places (though this does not necessarily mean that national origin identity is unimportant to a respondent). Thus, in places with a sizeable Asian population, greater diversity correlates with greater attachment to national origin identity in lieu of one's pan-ethnic one. However, in low diversity areas, large population areas report less importance of national origin identity. One's sense of "Asian" identity may be well-represented by their own national origin group if it is also the largest one in the community, as is suggested by the significant difference in the two Large Population/Low Diversity bars (diff = 0.09, std err = 0.03).

For robustness, Appendix Figures S2 and S3 recreate variants of Figure 2 based on two alternative codings of diversity: using a higher threshold at 50% and using HHI scores. HHI scores, though traditionally used to capture degree of market competition, similarly account for the dominance by a particular group in addition to the sizes of each group. In this robustness specification, High and Low diversity are determined relative to the mean of the distribution of the HHI scores across the set of zip codes in the ACS. Across the three robustness checks, I see generally similar patterns across locality types as in the main analysis.

Analysis of the 2016 CMPS data shows that identity importance varies across the four typologies, highlighting the importance of accounting for within-group diversity in addition to group size. Prior findings that show the importance of increasing population in increasing gains to group-based resources may be driven by a focus on places that are particularly homogeneous. Including group diversity in empirical examinations will help us better understand why there are not similar population effects in places that are more diverse. However, analysis of the CMPS data is descriptive and cannot tell us what the underlying local features are that may explain why we see such variation. To this end, I present evidence from novel survey data that is designed to show how diversity, when interacted with group size, potentially influences group identity through different types of resources.

Original Survey: Measuring Physical Versus Social Resources

What are the differences between locality types in the potential mechanisms that drive differences in identity importance? While pan-Asian identity may be conditional on a number of processes, such as perceived threat or exclusion, mobilization, social and organizational interactions, these mechanisms operate through institutional and social resources embedded in one's locality. I conceptualize these resources as two categories: physical resources related to organizational presence and social resources related to interactions with others. I measure these concepts using data from a novel survey, fielded across two time periods. The first version (Survey 1) was run in the summer of 2022 on two online survey platforms, Lucid Marketplace (n = 199) and Prolific (n = 1245) in the summer of 2022. A second iteration of the design (Survey 2), which included select survey questions from the first version as well as additional items, was fielded in the spring of 2023, again on Lucid Marketplace (n = 1,933) and Prolific (n = 976). The second run of the survey was conducted both to collect data on additional survey items as well as quota-sample across the four locality types. Quotas were only used on the sample from Lucid Marketplace, which allowed for targeting by respondent zip code. Summary statistics and distributions for the demographics of both samples are provided in Table S2-S4. Participants were eligible if they identified as Asian on pre-screen questions provided by both platforms and were paid between $1.50-1.75 for participating in the survey, which took about eight minutes to complete on average and was conducted in English. To categorize a respondent's locality type, I rely on the respondent's self-reported zip code and merge on the locality indicators created using data from the ACS.

What Matters for Group Identity?

As discussed in Anoll et al. (2025), the influence context has over identification can operate via different channels. I adopt this framing in the survey instrument by creating measures for two classes of resources that affect one's sense of group identity: physical resources and social relations. These two categories reflect the manifestation of group concentration and the identity-relevant processes arising from it. First, the physical presence of resources in a locality, including both community organizations and businesses, speaks to an individual's access to spaces that are oriented around group identity. Having a larger presence of these spaces in a locality can both contribute to one's sense of identity and whether one's national origin identity is emphasized. To measure this in the survey, respondents are asked about their experiences with community organizations and cultural centers, which often include programming around cultural events or provide language-specific resources, both of which contribute to one's sense of identity (questions provided in Appendix A). In addition to organizations, I draw on Wilcox-Archuleta

(2018) and ask respondents about the presence of ethnic restaurants and stores. Question wording for the individual items is provided in Appendix A1. The items are asked on a five-point Likert scale from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree" and then rescaled from 0 to 1. For analytic simplicity, I create an index by taking the average of the seven individual items. Summary statistics for the index and the individual items are also provided in Table S5.

Second, the concept of social relations in this setting focuses on factors that contribute to an individual's sense of group membership, particularly those related to group-based resources that are traditionally measured using attitudinal items such as group consciousness or linked fate (Wong et al. 2005). In the survey, the following items related to interactions with others, specifically: the extent to which they encounter other Asians and how connected they feel to other Asians and members of their national origin group. Frequent encounters of different Asian subgroups, which may be more likely in more diverse localities, may inform what "Asian" means in those localities and whether it follows a particular prototypicality or is more pan-ethnic in nature. Along these lines, respondents are also asked to what extent they feel connected to other Asians in their community and people with whom they share a national origin background. The general connection one feels towards others in their community likely affects whether one identifies with a broader, pan-ethnic identity relative to their national origin one. To support the development of these items, I provide descriptive results from a survey item that measures the importance different identity-relevant factors. Survey respondents are asked, "When you think of your Asian identity, which of the following are most important in contributing to your sense of identity?" Responses to this are presented in Appendix Figure S4. Family and friends, i.e. one's social network, are by far the most important factors respondents identify as contributing to their

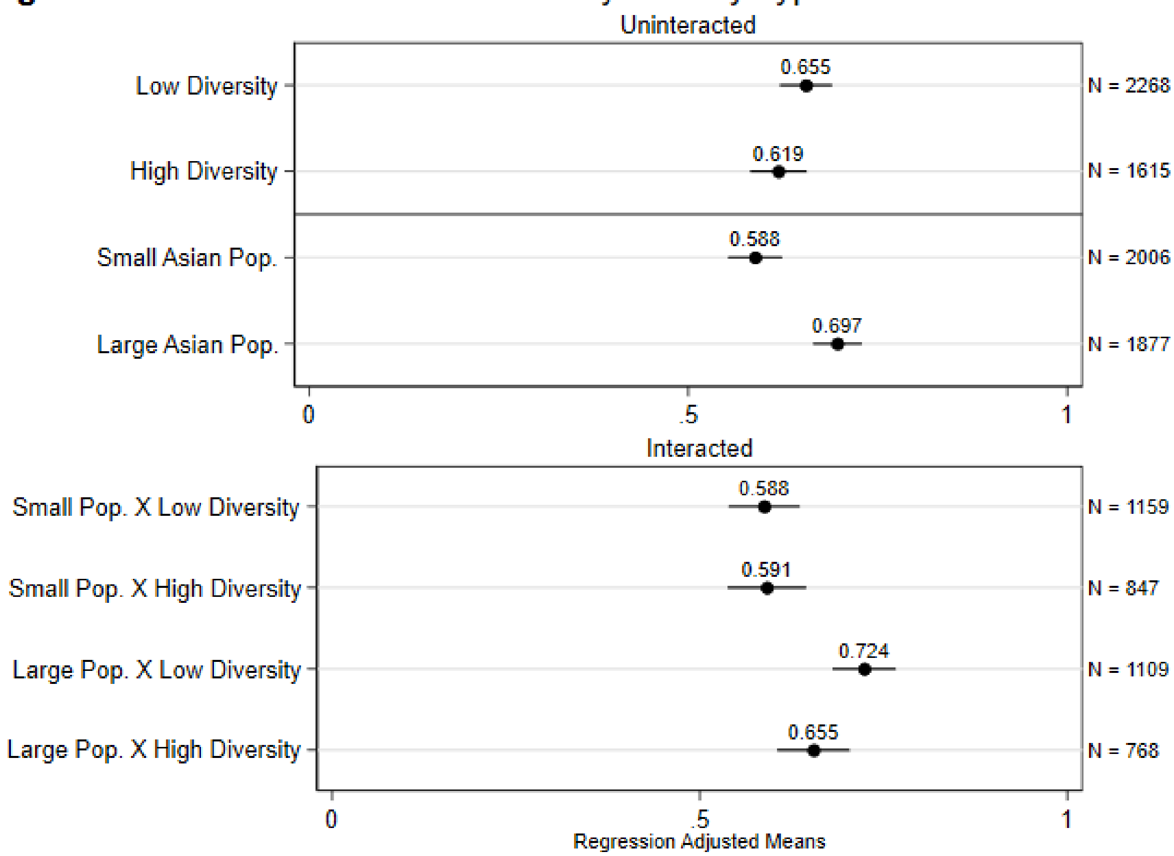
Asian identity. Food is also relatively salient, reinforcing the importance of including resources that increase access to and availability of food-related resources relevant to one's culture.

Physical and Structural Resources

Figure 3 presents regression-adjusted means for the resources measure across locality. Given that responses are from opt-in sample, I account for demographic variation by adjusting for respondent gender, age, and partisanship. For simplicity, I average the individual measures into one index for each respondent, with results for the individual items provided in the appendix (individual indices for Survey 1 and 2 reported Appendix Figure S5).

[Figure 3 about here]

Figure 3. Perceived Resources Index by Locality Type



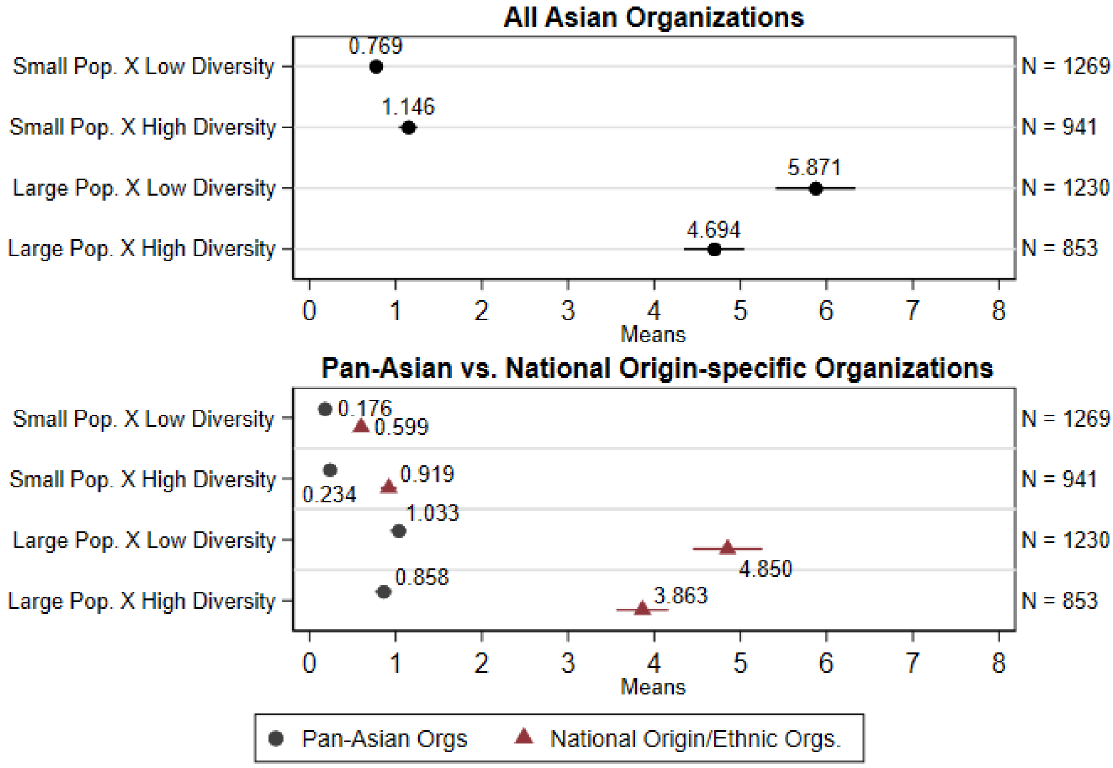
The top panel of Figure 3 presents means based on the uninteracted dimensions of locality, which are provided for baseline reference to better understand the means from the interaction between population size and diversity level, which are presented in the bottom panel. Taken at face value, we see there are no differences between High and Low diversity localities. As expected from prior work on group size, there is a significant difference between places that have larger Asian populations relative to smaller population areas. However, the interacted results reveal the importance of diversity within the context of group size. There is a significant difference in resources between places that are Large Population/Low Diversity and Small Population/Low Diversity, a difference that is not observed when comparing Large Population/High Diversity and Small Population/High Diversity. The role of group size is primarily driven by homogeneity of the Asian population.

I draw on theories on coalition-building to understand the salience of homogeneity (lower diversity) in generating physical resources – e.g., it may be easier to coordinate on community organization identities when there are fewer competing group interests (see Kim 2020a). Interestingly, I do not see significant differences between the types of resources – whether pan-Asian or national origin specific – across localities. Figure S6 in the appendix splits the main resources index into an index specific to pan-Asian organizations and businesses and one specific to national origin groups. While there are no distinct differences between indices within a locality type, the trends across localities are persistent regardless of if I use the pan-Asian or national-origin specific indices, with Large Population/Low Diversity localities having the highest score.

The survey responses measure what respondents *perceive* about their localities. How well do those perceptions track with the actual presence of organizations? I draw on IRS Form 990 data which provides a set of non-profit organizations by zip code. IRS Form 990 is completed by eligible tax-exempt organizations, data from which are collected and made available by the IRS as annual extracts. Relevant for this study, I use the IRS's Exempt Organization Business Master File Extract, which provides information from filers of Form 990, Form 990-EZ, and Form 990-PF. I restrict to organizations who filed a 990 form between 2015 and 2019 and remove duplicates (e.g., the same organization may have different Employer Identification Numbers in different years) and organizations with PO Box addresses. Using the names of the organizations, I code organizations as being either pan-Asian or national origin specific, with specific coding details provided in the Appendix. The survey measure in Figure 3 captures an individual's perception of the presence of both community organizations and business storefronts (restaurants, stores, etc.), while this measure of actual organization presence captures prevalence of organizations (and not businesses). The assumption here is that the number or proportion of businesses scales with the number of non-profit organizations in a given locality.

[Figure 4 about here]

Figure 4: Prevalence of Non-Profit Organizations by Locality Type



Analysis of the IRS data suggests that respondents' perceptions of organizations generally track with their actual presence. Figure 4 presents the presence of Asian organizations by locality type for zip codes represented in the original surveys, with all (Asian) organizations in the top panel and then separated out by whether the organization is pan-Asian or specific to a national origin group in the bottom panel. In the top panel, I observe similar patterns in the presence of organizations, with the greatest average number in localities that are Large Population and Low Diversity. As with the survey measure of physical resources, the difference between Low and High Diversity areas with Large Populations is statistically significant (diff = 1.18, $p < 0.01$). Thus, the survey measure of perceived presence of physical institutions appears to correspond with their actual presence. Notably, this difference holds even when I separate organizations by pan-Asian focus or national origin focus, as shown in the bottom panel of Figure 4. Moreover, the prevalence of pan-Asian organizations in Large Population and High Diversity areas becomes indistinguishable from those in either of the Small Population localities.

The analysis of the original survey data is limited to the zip codes of respondents in the survey, which may raise concerns about selection and representativeness of individuals who are more likely to take surveys and their localities. Appendix Table S3 reports the proportion of overall zip codes that are represented in either the 2016 CMPS or the original survey. Small population localities are especially underrepresented by survey sampling. To address this, Appendix Figure S10 presents the average number of organizations across *all* zip codes from the Census. Importantly, I find no statistically significant difference between the prevalence of organizations in Low vs. High Diversity, Large Population localities. This differs from the survey findings - the IRS-based outcomes are likely due to the underrepresentation of larger, more rural localities. To this end, I adjust the count of organizations in a zip code by land area to create a measure of organization density. Smaller zip codes, like those in urban areas, may have not only more organizations per ten-square mile but individuals in those areas are more likely to see those organizations. In contrast, organizations in larger zip codes may be more spread out. The bottom panel of Figure S7 presents organizational density across localities, which recovers the general pattern observed in Figures 3 and 4 (Figure S8 presents these results split by organization type).

Social and Intergroup Relations

The previous section highlighted the importance of physical and structural resources for Asian group identity. Are there similar differences across localities for resources that are more socially oriented? The following analysis suggests that physical and structural resources are more salient drivers of group identity than social processes.

[Figure 5 about here]

Figure 5. Intergroup Contact by Locality Type

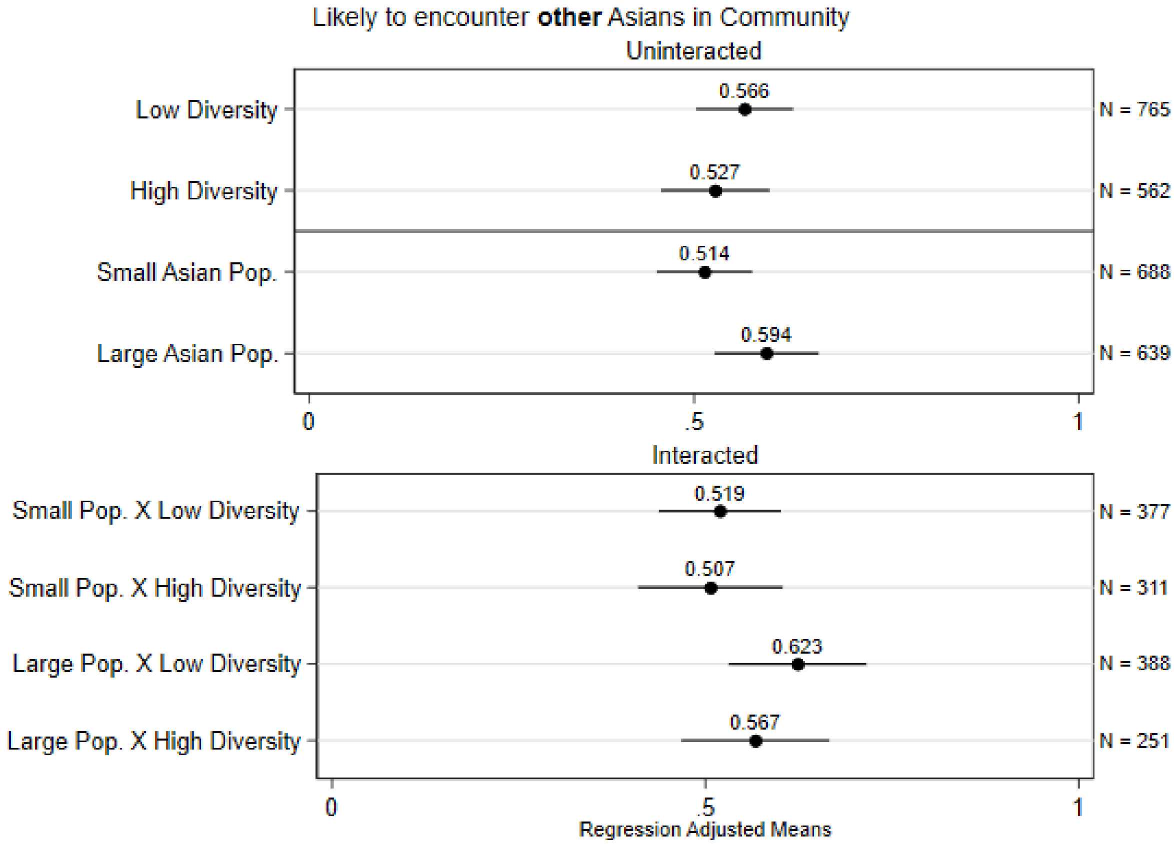
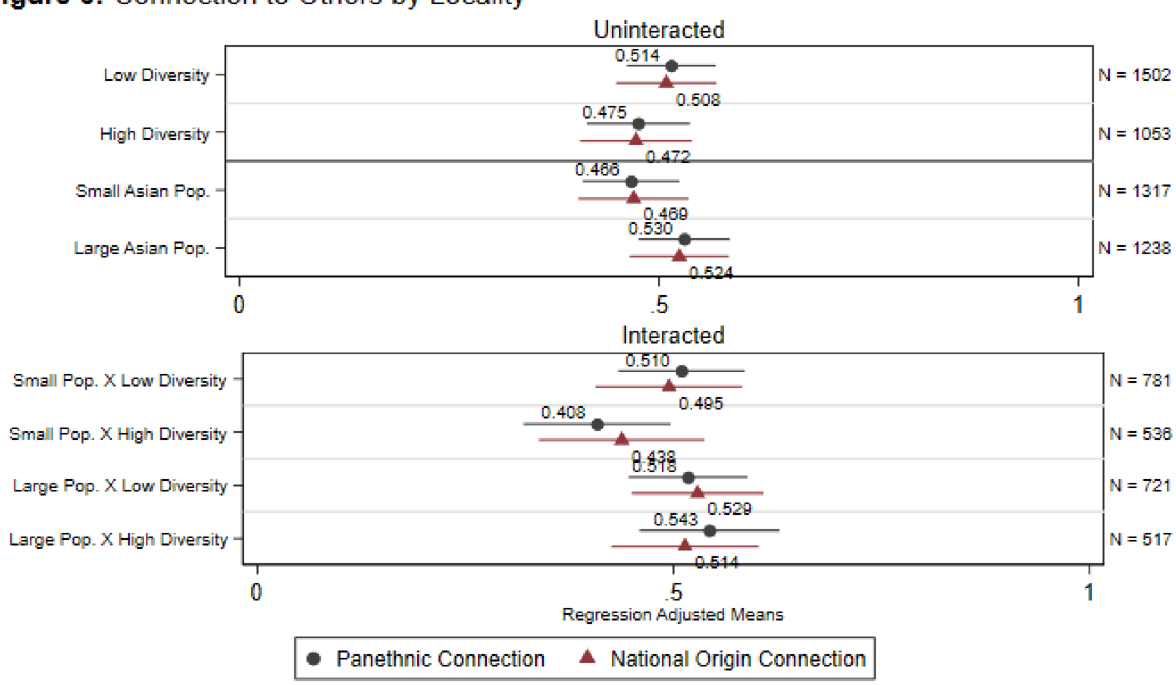


Figure 5 presents a similar set of descriptive analyses for the social relations items across locality types. Respondents are asked the extent to which they are likely to encounter different Asian subgroups in their daily lives and respond on a four-point Likert scale from "not at all" to "very often", which is then rescaled to take values from 0 to 1. The implicit assumption here is that seeing Asians from different subgroups, which is likely a function of population size and diversity, has some effect on one's perception of and orientation toward pan-Asian identity. I ask respondents about their interactions based on regional categories (i.e., East, South, Southeast Asian) rather than national origin due to the difficulty and problematic nature of trying to assume one's background based on physicality. Regionality does not address these concerns, but it at least allows for some measurement that is tractable.

Unlike the results for resources, the measure of intergroup contact does not suggest particularly notable differences between localities. One explanation could be attributed to the fact that these are self-reported perceptions of one's interactions with other Asians in the community. If groups are socially segregated, even in areas with large populations and high levels of diversity, the perception does not necessarily reflect the actual composition of groups in a given locality. However, the fact that respondents in Large Pop/Low Diversity localities report a higher salience of Asian identity, yet do not report similarly greater levels of intergroup contact may support the argument that frequency of contact with Asians from other regions, on its own, does not have much bearing on the salience of pan-Asian identity.

[Figure 6 about here]

Figure 6: Connection to Others by Locality



Using a different measure of group relations, Figure 6 presents the results for the measure of connection to others in one's community, split by connection to other Asians (Pan-ethnic Connection) and to other members of the respondent's national origin group (National Origin Connection). These items are asked on a four-point Likert scale and rescaled from 0 to 1. As with the intergroup contact measure, I again find a similar lack of differences across locality types. Additionally, there do not appear to be differences between connections to one's specific national origin group or Asians more generally. This may seem counterintuitive: we may suspect that greater diversity increases competition between national origin subgroups and dilutes the cohesiveness of a pan-Asian identity; but a weaker pan-ethnic identity does not negate its existence entirely. It could be the case that greater divisions spur coalition building across subgroups (Kim 2020), leading to hard-won ties that are observationally equivalent to connections in other locality types where connection is easier to come by. Notably, the lack of significant variation in social relations between localities need not be dispositive of the expectation that Large Population/Low Diversity areas are unique in their ability to maintain a pan-ethnic group identity. Rather, we can interpret the results to suggest that physical and structural resources are more overtly present than social ones in localities with larger, more homogenous communities and subsequently are likely more obvious in how identity-specific processes are facilitated. The social and psychological processes that drive identity creation and importance likely function through channels that are not tied solely to local context.

Appendix B provides an additional source of potential interactions that may influence one's group identity: religiosity. Religious affiliation and institutions offer a community space which facilitates social interactions and are particularly salient for certain Asian subgroups. Wilcox-Archuleta (2018) uses a respondent's religious attendance as a measure of social interactions between co-ethnics that increases attachment to pan-ethnic identity. I expand this measure by considering religiosity more generally, relaxing the assumption that if religion does facilitate social contact, it may not necessarily be restricted to church attendance. In Figure B1, I find a different trend across localities, highlighting the role of religion particularly in localities that have small Asian populations.

In all, these descriptive results highlight the role of physical resources in reinforcing pan-Asian identity, as well as the relevance of national origin diversity when studying the consequences of population dynamics on group-based attitudes. In particular, areas with low levels of diversity and a relatively large Asian population are more likely to have physical resources and exhibit greater salience of individuals' sense of group identity.

Individualized Experience within the Asian Community

An unanswered question in the current analysis is whether an individual's membership in a dominant group matters in localities that have a dominant national origin group. Whether an individual is part of the largest group in a community likely affects the salience of a pan-Asian identity to that person. I present a regression model in which an individual's identity importance is a function of the size of a dominant outgroup (non-Asians), the size of the individual's own group with respect to total population, and the size of the individual's own group with respect to the Asian population specifically. An individual's group size relative to the overall population captures the degree to which one's own Asian subgroup competes with the dominant outgroup. On the other hand, group size relative to the Asian population captures the degree to which one's own Asian subgroup competes with other Asian subgroups. I suspect these population dynamics are salient in driving the importance of either pan-ethnic identification or subgroup identification given that the incentives to choose one over the other is a function of different outgroup pressures. I also include a covariate-adjusted model using individual-level demographic variables that have been noted in prior research to be relevant for group identification, such as generation, income, and education (e.g., Lien et al. 2003).

The regression results in Table 2 suggest the population factors that matter for pan-Asian identity importance are different than those that matter for national origin identity importance. Columns 1 and 2 show that it is only when one's own national origin group is increasing relative to the overall population that pan-Asian identity has any relevance. Conversely, what appears to matter for a respondent's national origin identity is their own group size, but specifically with respect to the Asian population. This comports with expectations of national origin identity being more salient than pan-Asian identity in cases when an individual's own group size constitutes a large proportion of the Asian population. However, this gain in national origin identity importance is likely limited by what is happening relative to the overall population size. As an individual's own national origin group increases in size with respect to the overall population, national origin identity decreases (in favor of pan-Asian identity).

Table 2. Identity Importance as Function of Respondent's Own Group Size

	Asian ID Importance (1)	Asian ID Importance (2)	Nat Origin ID Importance (3)	Nat Origin ID Importance (4)
Group size: Non-Asians	0.0113	0.0276	0.0829	-0.111
	(0.0728)	(0.0733)	(0.0707)	(0.0686)
Group size: Own group	0.408*	0.426**	-0.459**	-0.513***
(wrt total population)	(0.216)	(0.213)	(0.199)	(0.195)
Group size: Own group	-0.0268	-0.0607	0.245***	0.145**
(wrt Asian population)	(0.0737)	(0.0741)	(0.0747)	(0.0734)
Constant	0.291***	0.323***	0.242***	0.445***
	(0.0610)	(0.106)	(0.0584)	(0.111)
Observations	2,685	2,685	2,685	2,685
Covariates	No	Yes	No	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1. Covariate-adjusted specification results are provided in the Appendix in Table S7.

Discussion

In the study of politics and identity, it is often difficult to fully account for the factors that contribute to both the construction and maintenance of that identity and to the outcomes of interest. This study focuses on local context and introduces a dimension overlooked in prior work, group diversity, bringing into the fold intuitions from research on Asian American politics and national origin backgrounds. Using survey data from the 2016 CMPS, I find evidence that community context plays an important role in explaining Asian American political identity, particularly when factoring in the level of national origin diversity in a locality. Asian identity is most salient in places that have larger Asian population that are more homogeneous. Evidence from two original surveys additionally show that large population, low diversity localities are also where identity-based organizations and community resources are more prevalent and likely reinforce pan-Asian identification. The finding that physical and structural resources are more salient compared to social contact is consistent with an institutional account of identity maintenance. Physical institutions are not only a reflection of group identity, but also active in reinforcing it by providing spaces where membership is defined and practiced. Without accounting for group diversity in studying the role of context on group politics, we risk conflating multiple factors that enable a positive relationship between identity and behavior. If identity is a salient part of understanding these group behaviors – if we care about political outcomes as a function of population characteristics - we must contend with how identity is constructed such that it is a salient factor. These results highlight a framework for understanding politicized identities as not static reflections of one's circumstances and experiences but as a dynamic process in which one implicitly responds to those circumstances and experiences.

There are several limitations to the present analysis. First, the survey item used to measure a respondent's national origin background in the CMPS asked respondent to choose their *primary* background, which does not permit measurement of multiple national origin backgrounds. Given the non-trivial rates of mixed ancestry among Asian Americans (as well as mixed racial identity), being able to account for an individual's multiple national origin backgrounds is crucial. Second, while the CMPS measures Asian linked fate, there are not similar items for national origin identity. Given the importance of diversity of national origin groups in a locality, including additional questions that capture perceived connection and linked fate with other members of one's national origin group will help better contextualize responses to items on the attitudes towards the broader pan-Asian group.

Second, while these population-based measures can only proxy a community context, subsequent research focusing on exactly how they proxy community context will provide fruitful insights to this topic. For example, Anoll et al. (2024) introduces measures of context based on social and psychological factors that are weakly correlated with each other. An important observation here is that one's community, and one's experiences within it, cannot be randomized. This points to a concern about selection: it is likely the case that localities where there is greater need for a pan-ethnic identity develop and provide the resources for pan-Asian identity to grow and become salient. Thus, the present study could simply be measuring the effect of *manifestations of* group identity importance on group identity importance itself. This concern may be mitigated to some degree by the fact that institutions are relatively "sticky" (Boettke et al 2008). The presence and prevalence of structural institutions that contribute to the development of group identity are likely a consequence of the population dynamics that created the need for a pan-ethnic identity in the first place.

Third, with regards to methodology, the presented survey design suffers from a limitation of being conducted primarily in English. This naturally excludes potential, eligible participants who would have taken the survey in another language. While this concern extends beyond the present study and reflects more general issues around opt-in online survey pools, advances in surveying technology will likely improve language-based accessibility for future endeavors. Moreover, the original survey design does not provide sufficient insights into which specific mechanisms are at play, just that there are differences across localities of those measured. Future work examining the conditions under which certain institutional or social features are more influential will prove valuable.

Finally, the measure of diversity used in this study is limited in its focus on numerical dominance. Within-group diversity of heterogeneity measured as a function of relative population size only tells us about the presence of groups relative to each other. Little can be inferred about the actual competitiveness and relationships between subgroups that may additionally lead to the patterns in local resources and institutions that we observe. Extant measures of diversity primarily focus on single dimensions, such as relative group size or physical segregation. We do not yet know how these different measures perform in relation to each other or what other factors might be necessary in understanding internal group dynamics. As such, the intuitions drawn from this measure may not be applicable to localities where context facilitates diversity-relevant processes differently. There are potential concerns around external validity in cases where the dominant group in a locality is not one of the larger national origin groups. Diversity and group size in such a context likely reflect different racializing processes than in localities where Chinese or Indian communities constitute the dominant group. Future work examining within-group diversity will benefit from considering more refined and sophisticated measures of diversity that account not only for numerical composition, but also for differences in culture, physical geography, and socioeconomic factors, all of which may contribute to group heterogeneity.

Broadly, this study is an initial foray into studying the politicization of group pan-ethnicity from a perspective of local context. Extant research already explores conditions under which cross-racial coalitions can form. Future research on group identity and context can focus on place-based factors that facilitate the emergence and reinforcement of group boundaries. The ability of identity-based coalitions, developed in response to context, to function as politically viable units depends on the environments in which they emerged. Though the study focuses on Asian Americans, these insights are likely applicable to other groups whose membership is constituted largely by immigrant members. Such communities are comprised of disparate subgroups and whose pan-ethnic or group identity is constructed in part due to external forces and emerges through shared local experiences. Moreover, the measure of diversity used in the present study proxies heterogeneity by the presence, or lack thereof, of a numerically dominant group. This presents a theoretical limitation in our ability to understand the particular political dynamics among and between specific groups. Future studies ought to consider additional dimensions of heterogeneity, such as socioeconomic factors or positionality with other non-White racial groups, as well as physical distribution or composition of national origin subgroups.

Endnotes

[1] Where relevant, the use of "Asian" over "Asian American" reflects a conception of pan-Asian identity that results from a process of racialization, one which often occurs irrespective of an individual's citizenship status. Likewise, "Asian American" can reflect an individual's actual citizenship status, as well as one's identity attachment in spite of citizenship status.

Figure Notes
Figure 1: Data are from the 2018 American Community (N = 21,506) and the 2016 CMPS (N = 2,985).
Figure 2: Population and Diversity are calculated at the zip code-level. Data are from the Census and 2016 CMPS.
Figure 3: n/a
Figure 4: n/a
Figure 5: Data are from Survey 1.1. *Other* refers to Asians from other national origin groups based on regionality.
Figure 6: n/a

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Online Appendix

Appendix A. Survey Design and Recruitment

A1. Question Wording

Resources and Organizations

To what extent would you agree with the following statements:

- My city/town has community centers and organizations that cater to Asians and Asian Americans
- My city/town has community centers and organizations that cater to [R's national origin] culture
- I frequently attend events hosted by Asian community organizations in my neighborhood
- There are many restaurants in my city/town based on Asian-cuisine
- There are many [R's national origin] restaurants in my city/town
- It is easy for me to buy groceries to make [R's national origin] dishes
- There are [R's national origin] grocery stores in my city/town

Intergroup Relations

How frequently would you say you encounter people who are…

- East Asian (e.g., Chinese, Taiwanese, Korean, Japanese)
- South Asian (e.g., Bangladeshi, Indian, Pakistani)
- Southeast Asian (e.g., Malaysian, Filipino, Vietnamese, Hmong, Thai, etc.)
- White
- Black or African American
- Latino or Hispanic

To what extent do you agree with the following statements:

- I feel connected to other Asians in my community
- I feel connected to other [R's national origin] people in my community

A3. Sample Recruitment

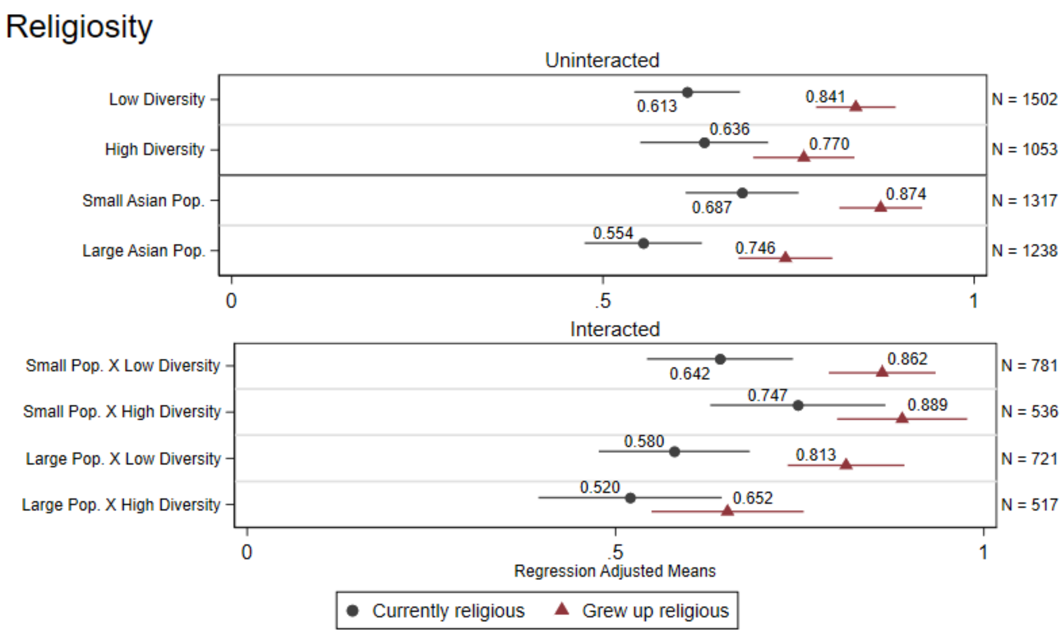
Respondents for the survey were recruited through Lucid Marketplace and Prolific. Lucid Marketplace is an online survey platform that allows researchers to recruit participants directly from survey vendors (as opposed to Lucid Theorem, which recruits participants on behalf of the researcher). Respondents recruited from Lucid were paid $1.50 for completing the survey. Additional respondents were recruited from Prolific and paid $1.75 for completing the survey. These pay rates correspond to $11 and $13 per hour, respectively. Before any survey questions were asked, respondents were shown a consent form page outlining the details of their involvement and how their data were to be collected. Respondents were required to consent to the study terms prior to entering into the survey and were paid the $1.50-1.75 regardless of whether they passed the attention check question. For both samples, respondents were pre-screened and eligible for the survey only if they reported identifying as Asian American or Asian. Survey recruitment procedures and questionnaires were approved by [Institutional IRB redacted].

Appendix B. Additional Sources of Contact

Religion

Figure B1 presents the results on religiosity, split by the respondent's current religious status (1 = currently religious, 0 = not currently religious) and whether the respondent was raised in a religious household (1 = yes, 0 = no). Perhaps unsurprising, while a relatively high proportion of respondents indicate having grown up in a religious household, a significantly smaller proportion report being religious in their current lives. There are notable differences by population – we see that respondents from Small Population localities are more likely to be currently religious and to have grown up in a religious household. There do not appear to be similar differences by diversity levels. However, the results from the interacted model reveal significant differences in religiosity between Small and Large Population localities that have High Diversity. These differences due to population do not appear if we look at Low Diversity localities. While the role of religion in structuring pan-ethnic identity is unclear based on these analyses, that there is a significantly higher proportion of Asians who are religious in High Diversity areas based on population suggest avenues for future research focusing on localities with smaller Asian populations.

Figure B1. Religiosity by Locality



Appendix C. Coding for Non-profit Organizations

To measure actual presence of Asian non-profit organizations, I used data from IRS 990 tax forms, provided by the National Bureau of Economic Research (https://www.nber.org/research/data/irs-form-990-data). In particular, I use the Exempt

Organization Business Master File Data extract, which provides both organization name and address. I use the address, specifically zip code, to merge on indicators for locality type. I use the organization name to identify it as an Asian organization, as well as to further categorize it as either national origin specific (e.g., “Japan America Society of Greater Philadelphia”) or pan-Asian only (e.g., “Asian American Advocacy Fund” and doesn’t include national origin-specific organizations). In addition to using phrases related to country names and pan-ethnicity (e.g., “Asian”, “AAPI”), I consulted online lists (e.g., https://www.ncapaonline.org/member-organizations/) of Asian American and national origin organizations in the US to manually include organizations that would not be otherwise be captured.

I use IRS activity codes to restrict the organizations to those that ostensibly contribute to or promote pan-ethnic or national-origin specific community. The IRS classifies organizations by their purpose using NTEE codes. From these codes, I keep organizations with NTEE codes covering the following activities: religious/churches, education and youth development, arts and culture, professional/employment resources, sports and recreation, community resources and support, and civil rights and advocacy. Finally, I remove organizations with PO Boxes as an address to ensure that the data include organizations with physical locations (though, the results are similar if organizations with PO Boxes are included in the sample).

Appendix D. Appendix Tables

Table S1. Distribution of Proportions in US Zip Codes

Percentile	Relative Proportion of Largest Asian Subgroup in Zip Code
1%	0.257
5%	0.304
10%	0.334
25%	0.405
50%	0.518
75%	0.666
90%	0.800
95%	0.868
99%	0.951
Mean	0.543
Std Dev	0.173

Note: Zip codes with no Asian residents are excluded.

Table S2. Sample Demographics

	2016 CMPS		Survey	
	N	Mean	N	Mean
Demographics				
Age		40.283		28.362
Female	1790	0.598	681	0.49
Male	1195	0.4	676	0.487
Other/Prefer not to say	6	0.002	32	0.023
Hispanic/Latino	17	0.006	18	0.013
Generation 1	1356	0.453	383	0.276
Generation 2	1067	0.357	825	0.594
Generation 3	265	0.089	167	0.12
Generation 4+	303	0.101	-	-
Partisanship				
Democrat	1256	0.42	869	0.626
Republican	594	0.199	104	0.075
Independent	949	0.317	324	0.233
Country of Origin				
China	1046	0.35	493	0.355
India	475	0.159	214	0.154
Philippines	404	0.135	181	0.13
Japan	357	0.119	77	0.055
Korea	206	0.069	135	0.097
Vietnam	202	0.068	206	0.148
Bangladesh			31	0.022
Cambodia			24	0.017
Taiwan			84	0.06
Indonesia			12	0.009
Laos			16	0.012
Malaysia			12	0.009
Myanmar			5	0.004
Singapore			8	0.006
Thailand			23	0.017
Pakistan			41	0.03
Other			52	0.037
Total	2991		1389	

Table S3. Distribution of Locality Types

Locality	Census (ACS) N	Census (ACS) %	2016 CMPS N	2016 CMPS %	Survey N	Survey %
Large Asian Pop. & High Diversity	484	0.023	584	0.196	262	0.188
Large Asian Pop. & Low Diversity	778	0.036	797	0.267	399	0.286
Small Asian Pop. & High Diversity	3364	0.156	720	0.241	332	0.238
Small Asian Pop. & Low Diversity	16880	0.785	884	0.296	399	0.287
Total	21506		2985		1392	

Notes: Data from zip codes with no Asian respondents in the ACS were excluded.

Table S4. Representativeness of Localities in Survey Samples

Locality Types	In Survey Samples			Not in Survey Samples		
	Proportion of all Zips	Mean Population	Land Area	Proportion of all Zips	Mean Population	Land Area
Large Pop x High Diversity	0.667	37474	1220.54	0.333	17682	907.04
Large Pop x Low Diversity	0.528	36948	1497.18	0.472	11992	5439.11
Small Pop x High Diversity	0.225	36864	2742.04	0.775	23243	5946.57
Small Pop x Low Diversity	0.060	31922	5090.11	0.940	9755	9999.4

Note: Land area is measured in square kilometers.

Table S5. Summary Statistics of Main Outcome Variables

Variable	Survey	N	Mean	Std. dev.	Min	Max
Resources Index	1, 2	4,332	0.611	0.236	0	1
Pan-ethnic Organizations	1, 2	4,331	0.562	0.295	0	1
Pan-ethnic Food Stores	1, 2	4,331	0.727	0.262	0	1
Ethnic Food Stores	1, 2	3,987	0.599	0.318	0	1
Can make ethnic dishes	1, 2	3,987	0.694	0.275	0	1
Ethnic Storefronts	1, 2	3,988	0.628	0.319	0	1
Ethnic Organizations	1, 2	3,983	0.461	0.321	0	1
Intergroup Contact Index	1	1,422	0.521	0.227	0	1
Likely to encounter East Asians	1	1,423	0.634	0.271	0	1
Likely to encounter Southeast Asians	1	1,423	0.548	0.269	0	1
Likely to encounter South Asians	1	1,422	0.526	0.275	0	1
Feels connected to other Asians	2	2,908	0.463	0.315	0	1
Feels connected to national origin members	2	2,618	0.462	0.325	0	1

Table S6. CMPS Analysis using OLS, base and covariate-adjusted

	Asian ID Importance	Asian ID Importance	Asian Linked Fate	Asian Linked Fate	Nat Origin ID Importance	Nat Origin ID Importance
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Small Pop	-0.00241	-0.00600	-0.000481	3.39e-05	-0.00738	-0.0418*
x Low Diverse	(0.0251)	(0.0254)	(0.0196)	(0.0197)	(0.0256)	(0.0253)
Small Pop	-0.000481	-0.00313	-0.00869	-0.0117	-0.0115	-0.0345
x High Diverse	(0.0262)	(0.0262)	(0.0205)	(0.0203)	(0.0267)	(0.0260)
Large Pop	0.0538**	0.0483*	0.0334*	0.0329*	-0.0654**	-0.0864***
x Low Diverse	(0.0260)	(0.0260)	(0.0199)	(0.0199)	(0.0256)	(0.0250)
Covariates						
Female		0.0508***		0.00141		0.0426**
		(0.0181)		(0.0140)		(0.0176)
Age		-0.00221***		-0.00301***		-0.00492***
		(0.000596)		(0.000460)		(0.000580)
Income						
(ref = <$30k)						
[$30k, $60k)		-0.0320		0.0207		0.0546
		(0.0354)		(0.0271)		(0.0357)
[$60k, $100k)		-0.0572*		0.00932		0.0248
		(0.0323)		(0.0246)		(0.0319)
[$30k, $60k)		-0.0571*		0.0138		0.0197
		(0.0310)		(0.0236)		(0.0302)
[$100k, $150k)		-0.0190		0.0522**		-0.0348
		(0.0343)		(0.0257)		(0.0327)
[$150k, $200k)		0.0420		0.0141		-0.0881**
		(0.0458)		(0.0341)		(0.0407)
>$200k		-0.00780		0.00199		-0.129***
		(0.0445)		(0.0338)		(0.0392)
Education						
(ref: < HS diploma)						
HS Diploma/GED		0.0324		0.0552		0.0571
		(0.0533)		(0.0423)		(0.0583)
Some college		0.107**		0.0569		-0.0221
		(0.0510)		(0.0402)		(0.0554)
BA		0.0442		0.108***		0.0374
		(0.0494)		(0.0393)		(0.0548)
Postgrad		0.0291		0.130***		0.0776
		(0.0506)		(0.0403)		(0.0562)
Constant	0.323***	0.367***	0.426***	0.435***	0.352***	0.509***
	(0.0194)	(0.0596)	(0.0151)	(0.0465)	(0.0199)	(0.0630)
Observations	2,938	2,937	2,985	2,984	2,938	2,937

Robust standard errors in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1. Covariate-adjusted specifications are run with the omitted category referenced above. The omitted category for locality is Large Pop x High Diversity.

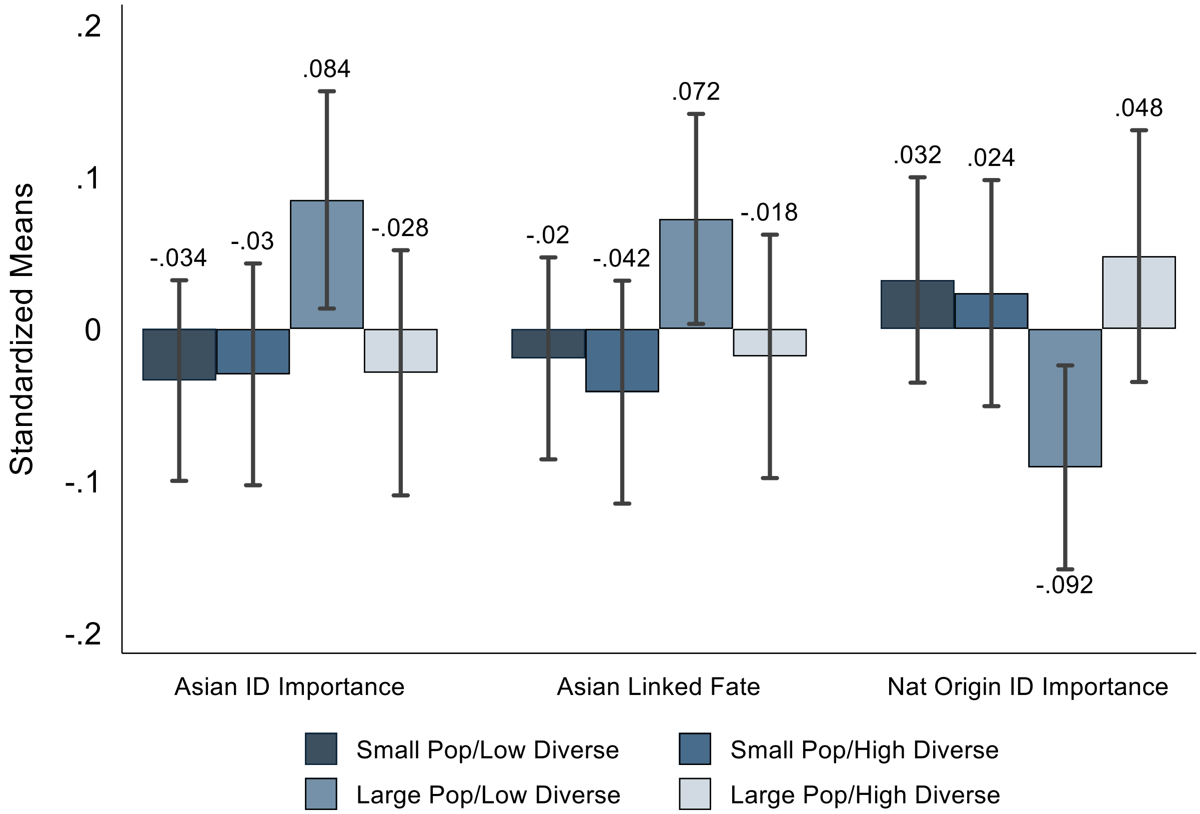
Table S7. Full Results for Regression Specifications in Table 2

	Asian ID Importance (1)	Asian ID Importance (2)	National Origin ID Importance (3)	National Origin ID Importance (4)
Group size: Non-Asians	0.0113	0.0276	0.0829	-0.111
	(0.0728)	(0.0733)	(0.0707)	(0.0686)
Group size: Own group	0.408*	0.426**	-0.459**	-0.513***
(wrt total population)	(0.216)	(0.213)	(0.199)	(0.195)
Group size: Own group	-0.0268	-0.0607	0.245***	0.145**
(wrt Asian population)	(0.0737)	(0.0741)	(0.0747)	(0.0734)
Generation 1		-0.0407		0.308***
		(0.0322)		(0.0276)
Generation 2		0.0871***		0.0679**
		(0.0335)		(0.0281)
Generation 3+		-0.0109		0.0494
		(0.0413)		(0.0329)
Female		0.0503***		0.0321*
		(0.0185)		(0.0178)
Age		-0.00562*		-0.00391
		(0.00322)		(0.00384)
Household Income				
\$30,000-\$59,999		-0.0435		0.0500
		(0.0369)		(0.0368)
\$60,000-\$99,999		-0.0636*		0.0153
		(0.0330)		(0.0322)
\$100,000-\$149,999		-0.0447		0.00639
		(0.0317)		(0.0304)
\$150,000-\$199,999		-0.0272		-0.0280
		(0.0348)		(0.0326)
\$250,000+		0.0463		-0.0762*
		(0.0467)		(0.0415)
Prefer not to say		-0.0128		-0.120***
		(0.0447)		(0.0400)
Education				
High School Diploma/GED		0.0665		0.00281
		(0.0587)		(0.0652)
Some College		0.149***		-0.0571
		(0.0568)		(0.0625)
Bachelor's		0.104*		-0.0334
		(0.0555)		(0.0624)
Postgraduate		0.0913		-0.0151
		(0.0567)		(0.0635)
Constant	0.291***	0.323***	0.242***	0.445***
	(0.0610)	(0.106)	(0.0584)	(0.111)
Observations	2,685	2,685	2,685	2,685
Covariates		Yes		Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

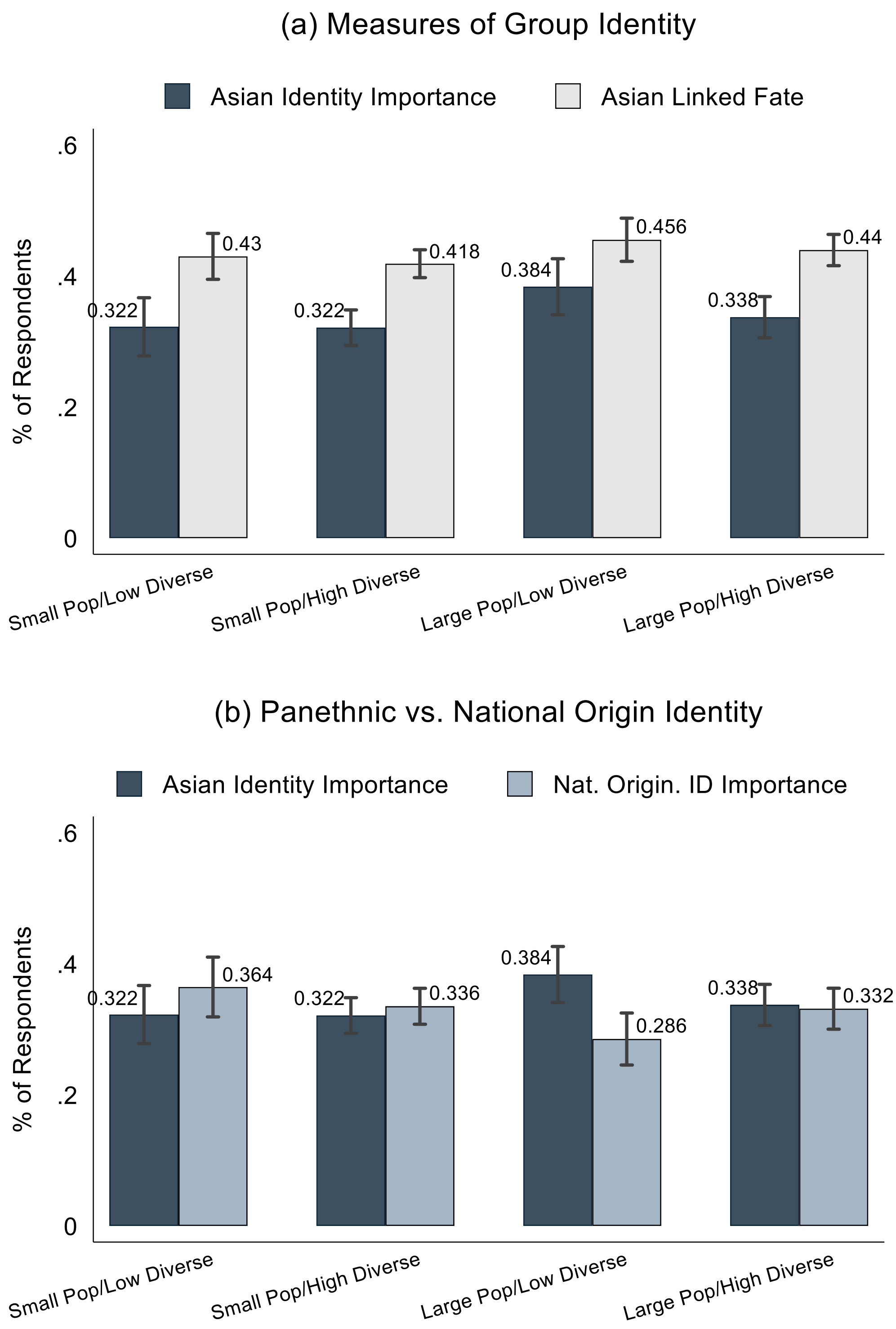
Appendix D. Appendix Figures

Figure S1. Group Identity and Behavior across Localities (2016 CMPS), Standardized Means



Population and Diversity are calculated at the zip code-level. Data from Census and CMPS.

Figure S2. Figure 2 Robustness with Diversity Threshold at 50%



Data from Census and CMPS. Population and Diversity are calculated at the zip code-level.
Low Diversity = largest group > 50%. Small population if < 15%.

Figure S3. Figure 2 Robustness with HHI Diversity Measure

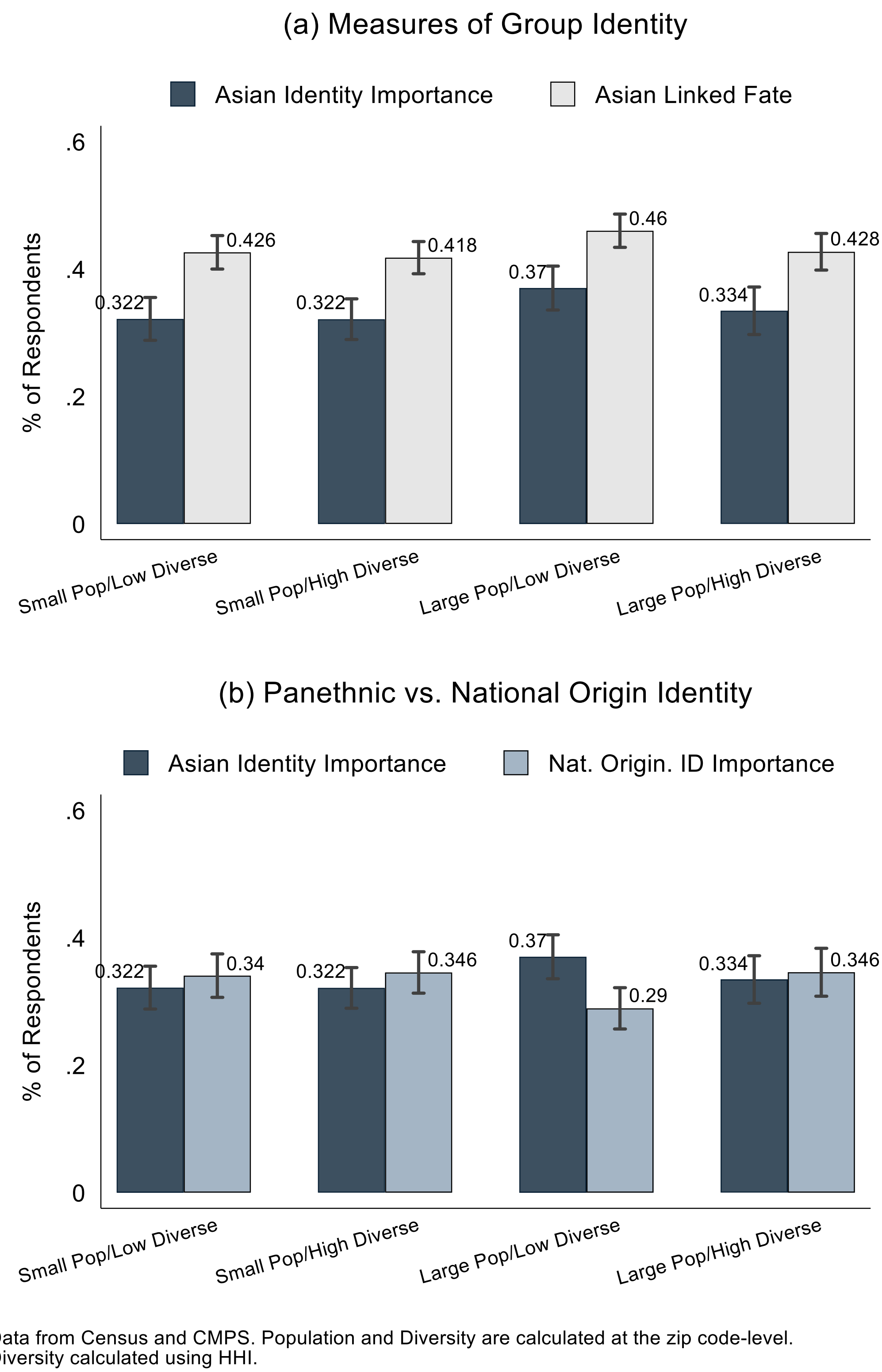
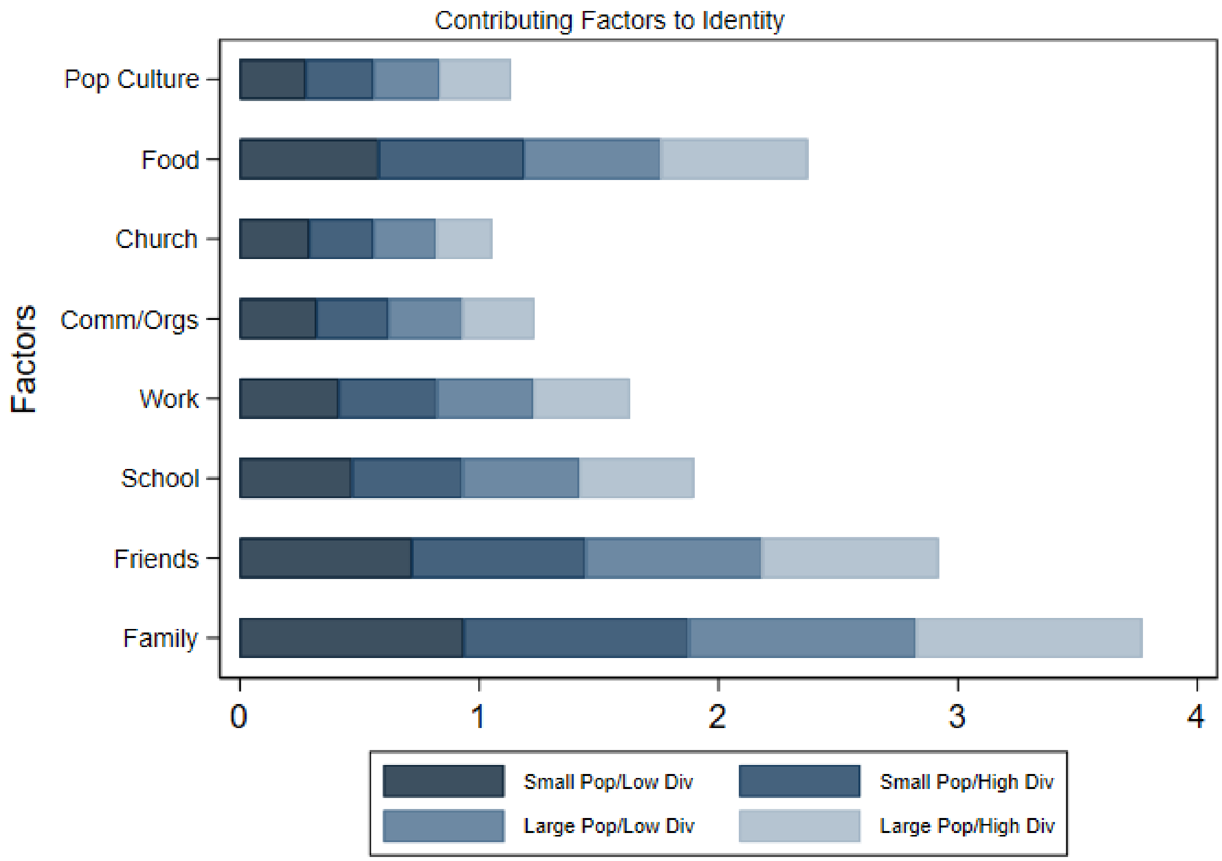


Figure S4. Important Factors to One's Pan-Asian Identity



Notes: Each locality-specific bar (differentiated by shade) represents the mean rankings of the relative importance of each factor, with respect to one another. Respondents are asked to rank-order the factors by how important they are to their Asian identity. Responses are recoded on an eight-point scale from 0 to 1. Higher values denote more importance. The overall bars for a given factor represent the cumulative mean rating over the four localities (i.e., it is not the average rating of a factor).

Figure S5a. Resources Measure from Survey 1

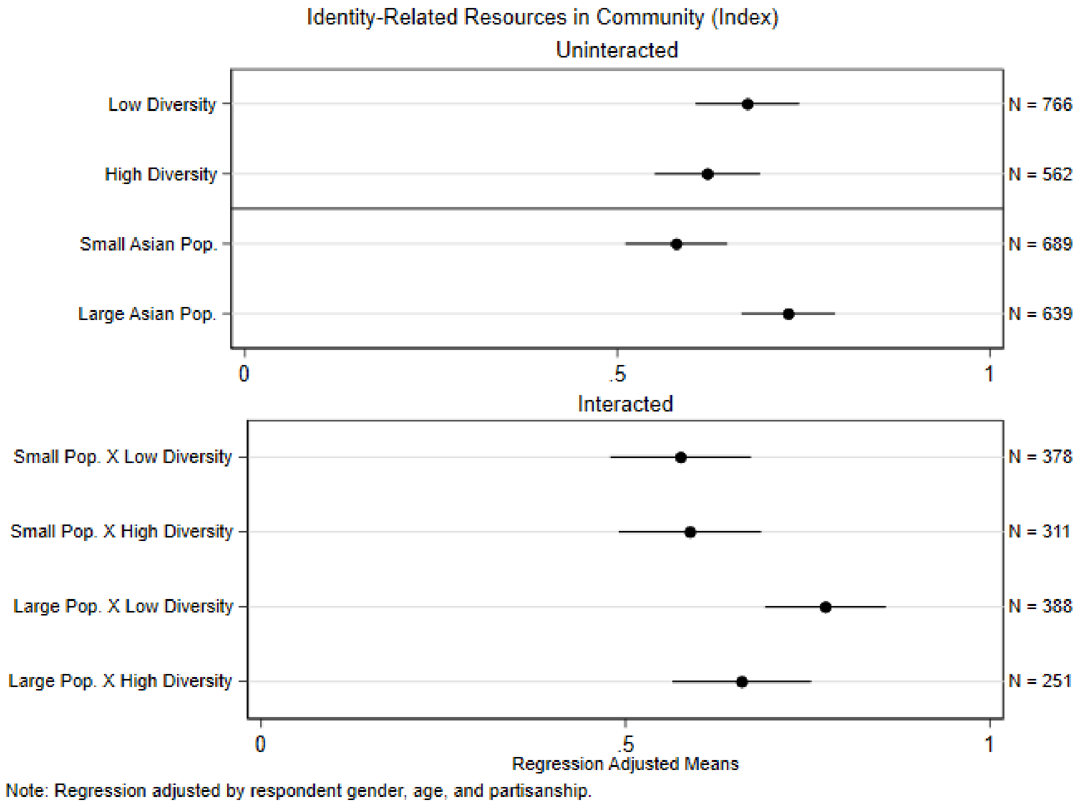


Figure S5b. Resources Measure from Survey 2

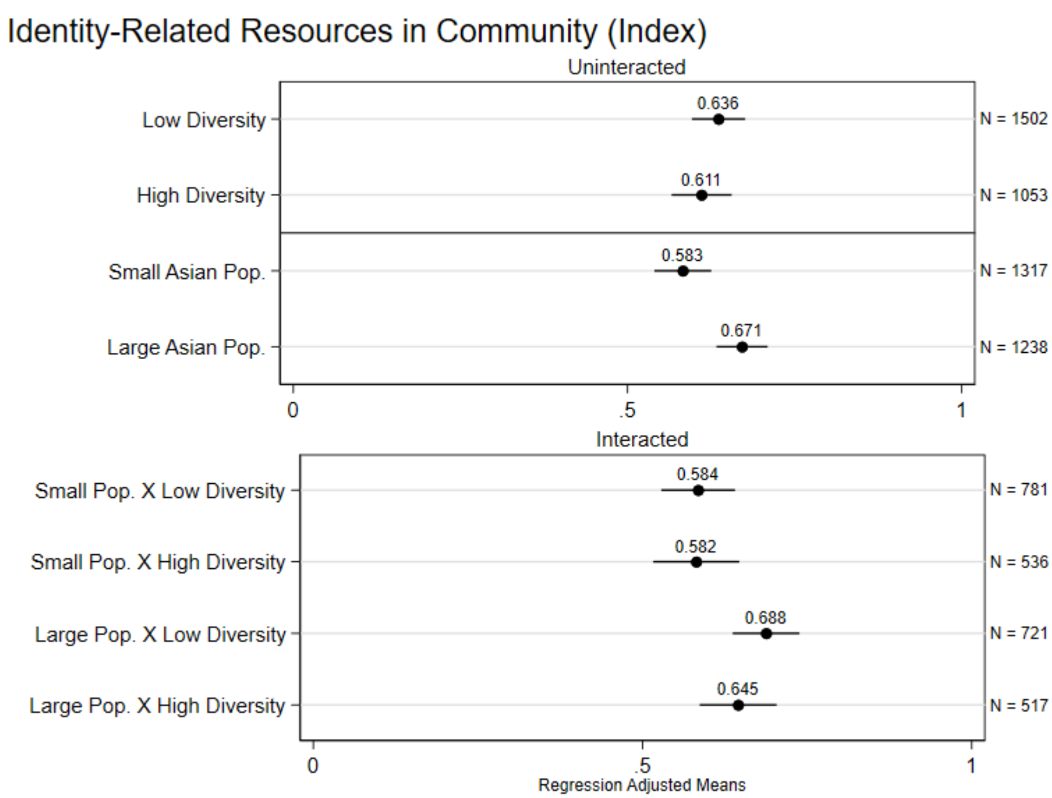


Figure S6. Resources Index by Pan-Asian and National Origin Focus (2015-2019)

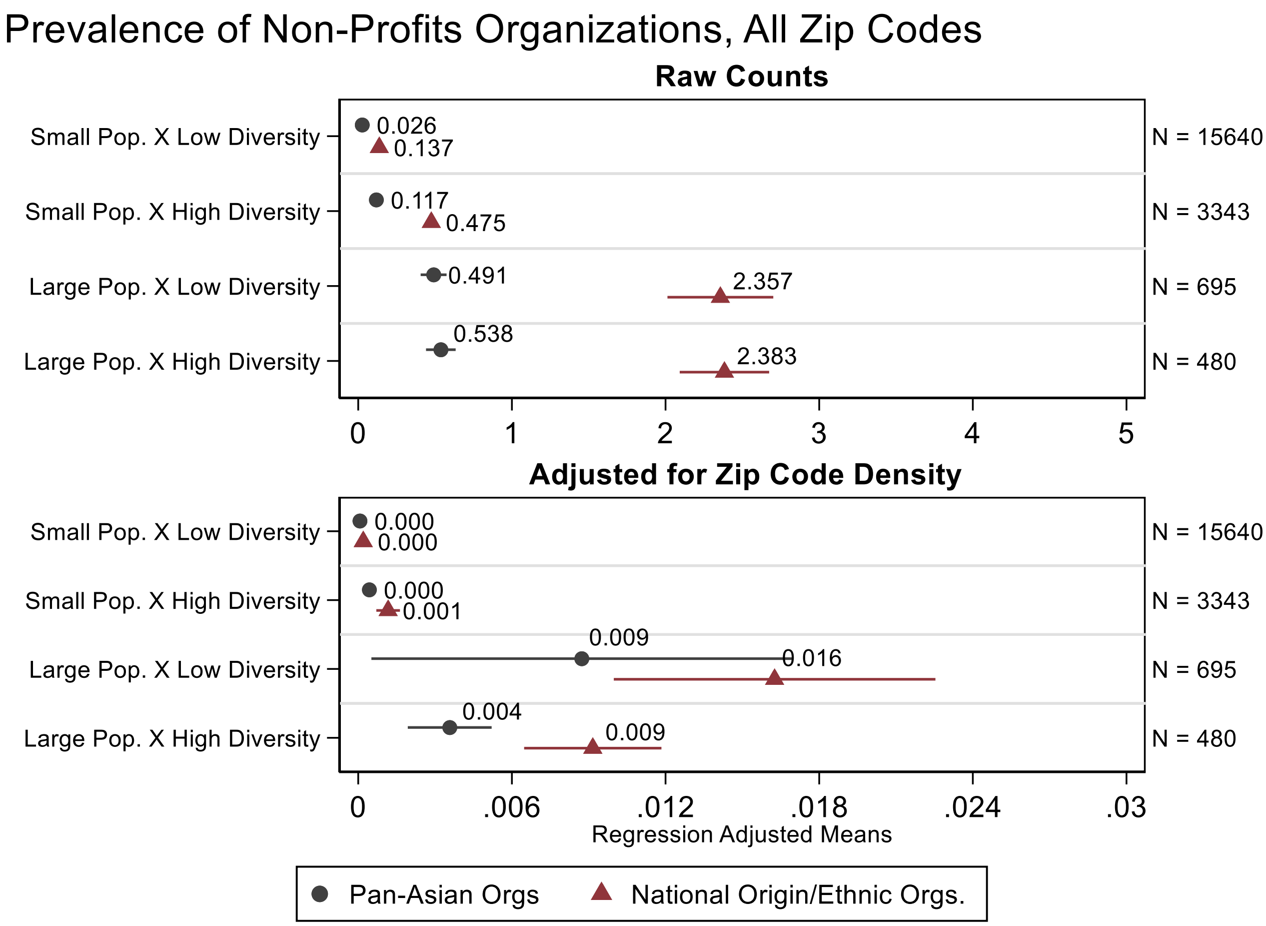


Figure S7. Non-Profit Organizations for all Zip Codes in Census (2015-2019), Pooled

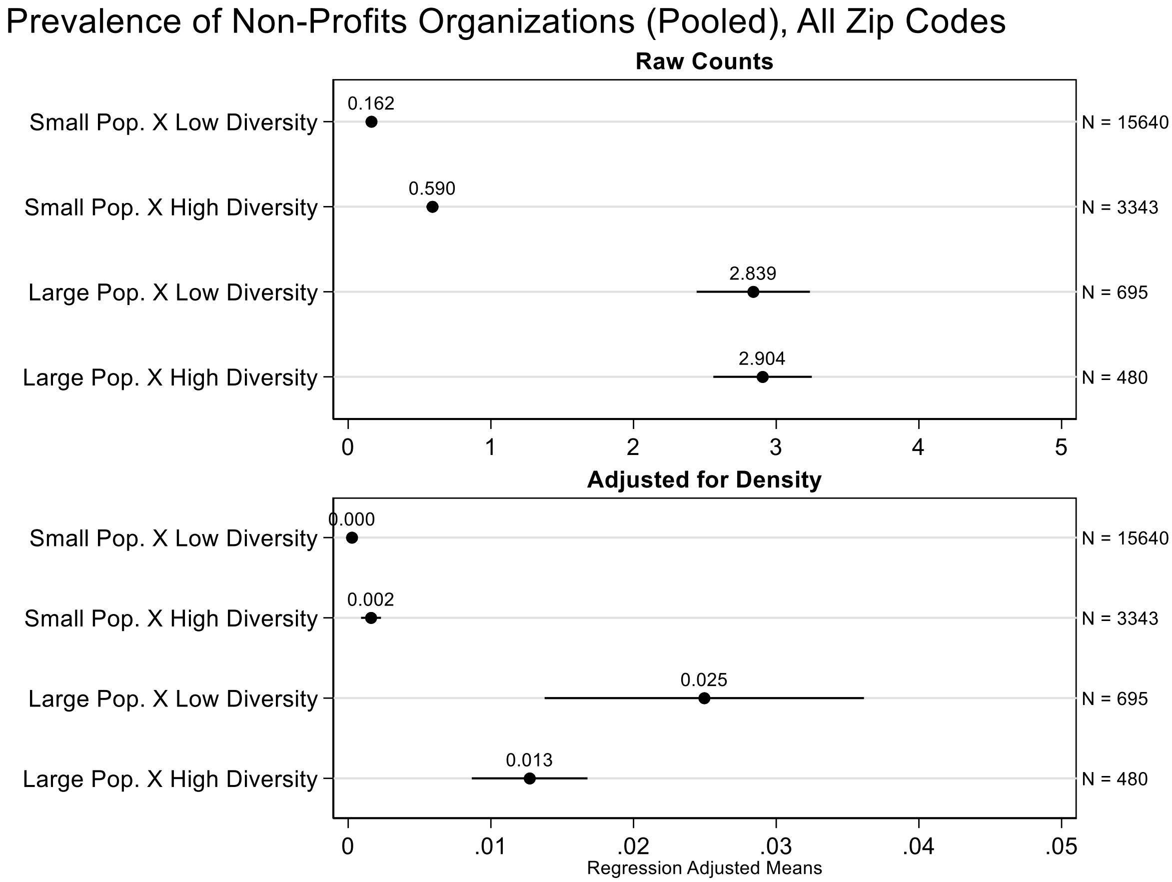


Figure S8. Non-Profit Organizations for all Zip Codes in Census (2015-2019), Pan-Asian vs. National Origin